European Commission

Survey Visualisation Report: Feedback of Horizon Europe Beneficiaries and Unsuccessful Applicants

Supporting the interim evaluation of Horizon Europe

Independent Expert Report



Research and Innovation

Survey Visualisation Report: Feedback of Horizon Europe Beneficiaries and Unsuccessful Applicants

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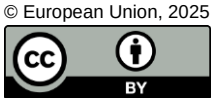
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Survey Visualisation Report: Feedback of Horizon Europe Beneficiaries and Unsuccessful Applicants

Supporting the interim evaluation of Horizon Europe

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LIST OF ACRONYMS

ABBREVIATION	DEFINITION
CAP	Common Agricultural Policy
CL	Cluster
COFUND	Co-funding of Regional, National, and International Programme
DG	Directorate-General
EC	European Commission
EIC	European Innovation Council
ERC	European Research Council
ERDF	European Regional Develpment Fund
ESF	European Social Fund
EU	European Union
FP	Framework Programme
GVC	Global Value Chains
IPR	Intellectual Property Rights
MSCA	Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions
NGO	Non-Governmental Organization
R&I	Research and Innovation
SMEs	Small and Medium-sized Enterprises
WIDERA	Widening Participation and Spreading Excellence Actions.

1. INTRODUCTION

This report presents the results of the analysis of a survey of beneficiaries and unsuccessful applicants in Horizon Europe. The survey was conducted between May and July 2023 to support the interim evaluation of the programme. Independent contractors developed and administered nine online questionnaires to gather evidence on the needs and motives for engaging with Horizon Europe, perceptions of expected project outcomes and impacts, and obstacles encountered during the application and project implementation. Five studies conducted by external evaluators, each covering a broad thematic area of the Horizon Europe programme, reported the survey results focusing on specific programme parts[1]. The purpose of the report at hand is to present the programme-level results and support the Commission's evaluation of Horizon Europe, which is due in April 2025.

1.1. Methodology

The survey programme encompassed all three pillars of Horizon Europe. For the programmes' **beneficiaries**, it included five different questionnaires to account for different programme parts, namely:

1. MSCA Postdoctoral Fellowships beneficiary researchers;
2. ERC beneficiary Principal Investigators (PIs);
3. Beneficiary organisations under collaborative actions, including:
    - Pillar I: MSCA (Doctoral Networks; Staff exchanges; and COFUND), Research Infrastructures.
    - Pillar II: Global Challenges & European Industrial Competitiveness (Clusters).
    - Pillar III: beneficiaries of European Innovation ecosystems;
    - Horizontal actions: WIDERA.
4. European Innovation Council (EIC): Pathfinder and Transition grants;
5. EIC Accelerator grants.

The survey of Horizon Europe's **unsuccessful applicants** included three questionnaires:

6. MSCA Postdoctoral fellowships and ERC);

[1] Dinges, M. and Coatanroch, G., Horizon Europe and the Green Transition – Interim evaluation support study – Final report ("Phase 2" study), Publications Office of the European Union, 2024, https://data.europa.eu/doi/10.2777/67934, Denham, S., Stančiauskas, V., Dėlkutė-Morgan, R., Kazlauskaitė, D. et al., Evaluation support study on Horizon Europe's contribution to a resilient Europe – Final report phase 2, Publications Office of the European Union, 2024, https://data.europa.eu/doi/10.2777/797281, Naujokaitytė, R., Cakić, M., Didžiulytė, M., Zharkalliu-Roussou, K. et al., Evaluation study of the European framework programmes for research and innovation for an innovative Europe – support study for the interim evaluation of Horizon Europe, Publications Office of the European Union, 2024, https://data.europa.eu/doi/10.2777/499132, Excellent Science and Digital and Industrial Transition (forthcoming in 2024).

7. Horizon Europe's collaborative actions, including:
    a. Pillar I: MSCA (Doctoral Networks; Staff exchanges; and COFUND), Research Infrastructures.
    b. Pillar II: Global Challenges & European Industrial Competitiveness (Clusters 1-6) grants.
    c. Pillar III: European Innovation Ecosystems grants and EIC Pathfinder and Transition grants.
    d. Horizontal actions: WIDERA.
8. EIC Accelerator grants.

The current analysis is based on a dataset created by merging the data from these separate questionnaires. Many of the questions are present in multiple questionnaires. For example, most questions covering the "Efficiency" evaluation criteria are broadly common across all surveys, with minor differences, making it possible to aggregate the results and generate descriptive statistics across several surveys.

However, the integration of these datasets was not straightforward. The questionnaires were designed to gather insights into specific programme components and included several differences in their structure that have to be incorporated and properly accounted for in the aggregated analysis. Due to variations in the wording of questions and response options, a thorough process of data cleaning and consolidation was necessary to ensure a comprehensive analysis of the responses. This task required several manual checks.

First, mapping questions across different surveys was necessary to identify which questions were identical and which were distinct, allowing for the integration of similar data points while maintaining the integrity of unique responses. Second, it was important to distinguish between empty values and "not applicable" responses, ensuring that the data was interpreted correctly. Third, the process involved harmonising the wording and formatting of questions and response options, which was needed to ensure consistency across the dataset, enabling comparison of responses. Finally, managing the free-text response options added by respondents in multiple columns posed an additional challenge, as these needed to be carefully organised and integrated into the overall dataset without losing the nuance or intent of the respondents' answers.

1.2. Synopsis of the survey programme

The survey invitations were sent to all the Horizon Europe beneficiaries and unsuccessful applicants under the relevant programme parts. This strategy allowed collecting survey answers from the maximum number of respondents. Before sending the survey invitations, several steps were taken to clean and prepare the eCORDA contact data. This involved removing ineligible or irrelevant applications, filtering out irrelevant calls, program parts, and contact types, and eliminating duplicate contacts to ensure each individual received only one survey invite per project. Contacts who had previously requested not to be contacted were also removed, along with invalid email addresses. After these steps, the final contact list included 111,095 unique individuals, comprising 28,843 successful applicants and 82,252 unsuccessful applicants.

Figure 1 presents the survey response rates by program component. Both the total number of completed responses and the percentages indicating representativeness within each group are illustrated.



Figure 1 Survey response rate across Horizon Europe programme's parts

To ensure that there were no underrepresented groups among the different programme parts covered in the survey, the distribution of survey responses by type of organisation was also assessed. The analysis showed that there were no underrepresented groups, and the response pool reflected the structure of Horizon Europe's applicant population (Figure 2).

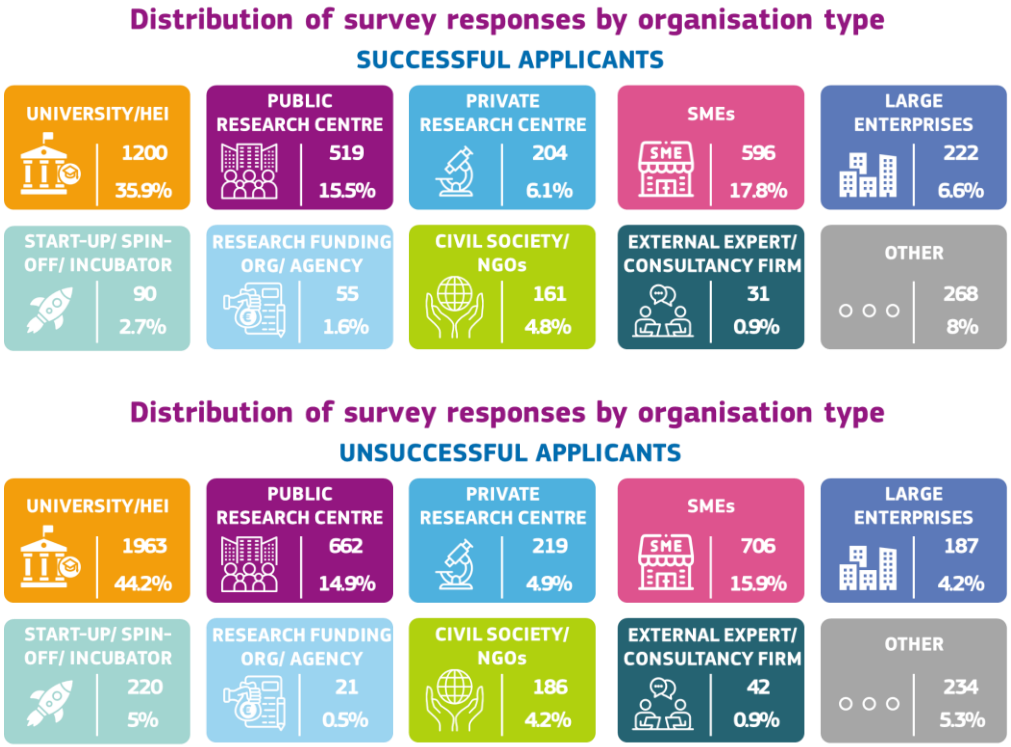


Figure 2 Survey response rate by categories of stakeholders

2. Survey Results

The following subchapters present the survey results. For each question, the respondents are identified as either project beneficiaries or unsuccessful applicants. The specific programme component(s) addressed by each question, along with the related options, are also indicated. Variations in questions and options reflect the unique characteristics of different parts of the Horizon Europe programme. For example, questions and options related to consortium setup or management are not relevant for mono-beneficiaries such as ERC, MSCA, and the EIC Accelerator. Only valid responses are included in the analysis.

2.1. Efficiency

*To what extent are you satisfied with the following aspects related to your **project application process**?*

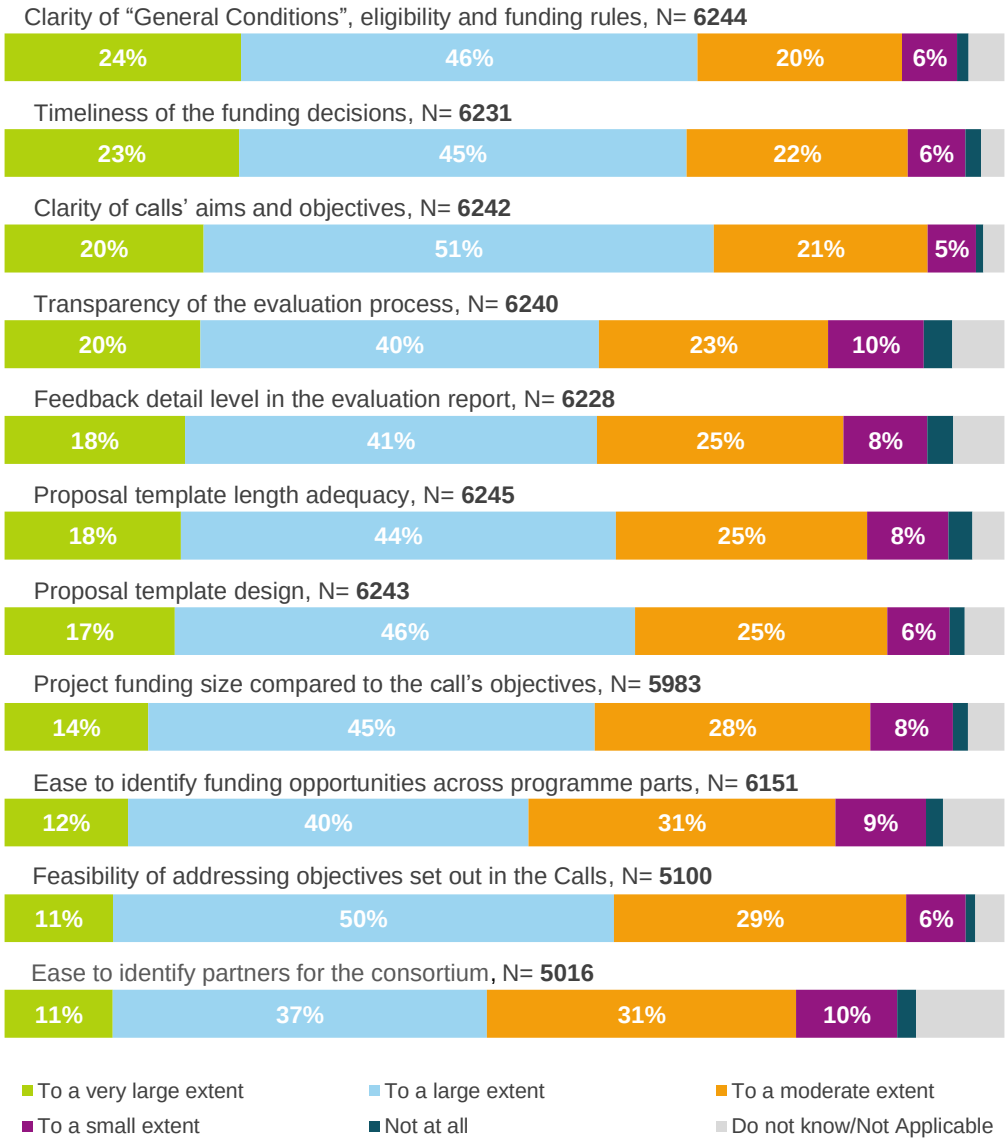


Figure 3 Project application process' satisfaction rate

Programme beneficiaries. The option "The size of the possible project funding as foreseen in the call compared to the objectives set in the call" was not available in the ERC questionnaire. The options "Ease to identify relevant partners for the consortium" and "Feasibility of addressing the objectives set out in the Calls" were not available in the ERC, MSCA and EIC Accelerator questionnaires.

*To what extent are you satisfied with the following **changes in the application process** introduced under Horizon Europe?*

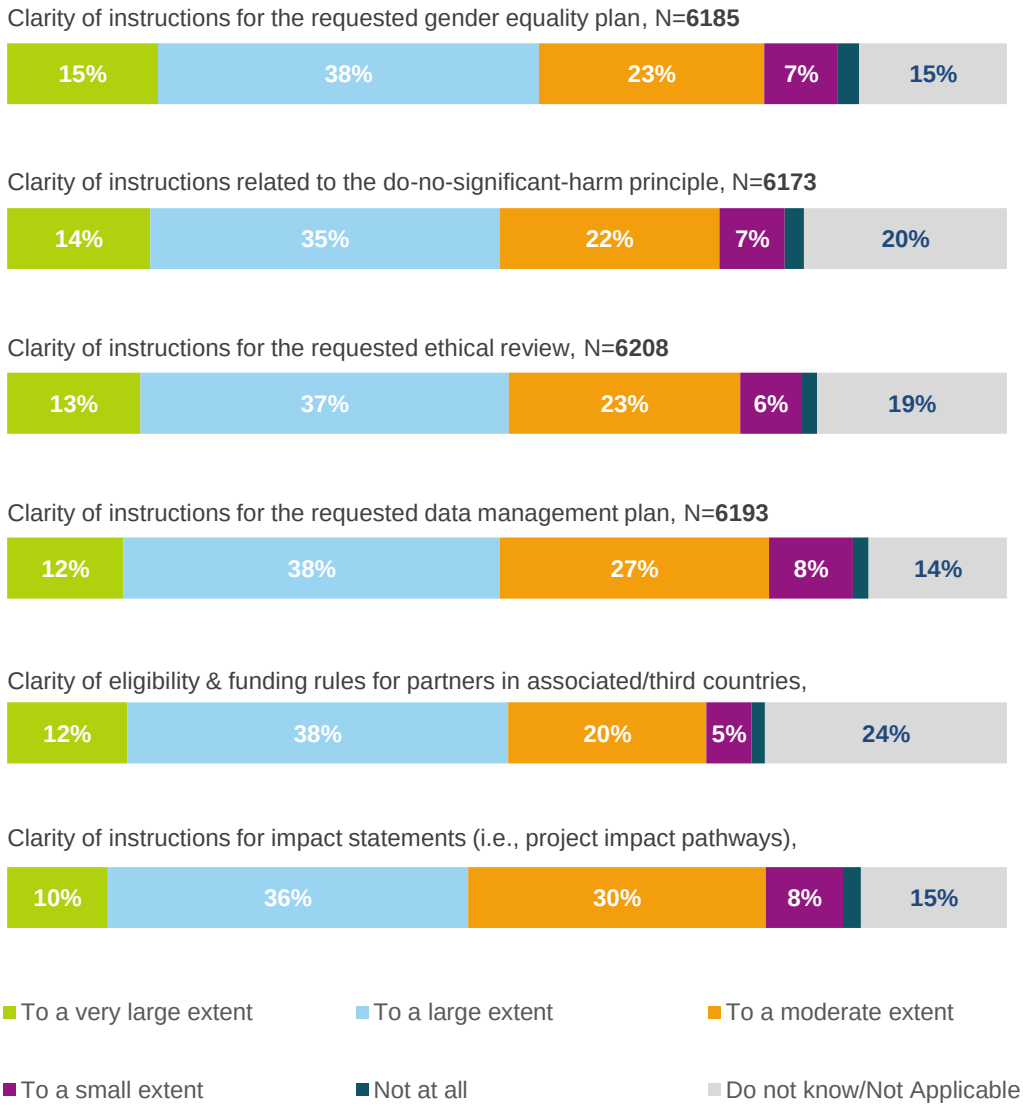


Figure 4 Changes in the application process' satisfaction rate

Programme beneficiaries. The option "Clarity of instructions for the development of impact pathways" was not included in the questionnaires of ERC and MSCA participants. The option "Clarity of the eligibility funding rules for partners in associated countries" was not included in the questionnaires of ERC, MSCA and EIC participants.

Note: The Do-No-Significant-Harm principle implies that research and innovation activities should not support or carry out activities that create significant harm to any of the objectives of the European Green Deal.

*To what extent do you agree with the following statements about **the effort needed to prepare and submit your proposal**?*

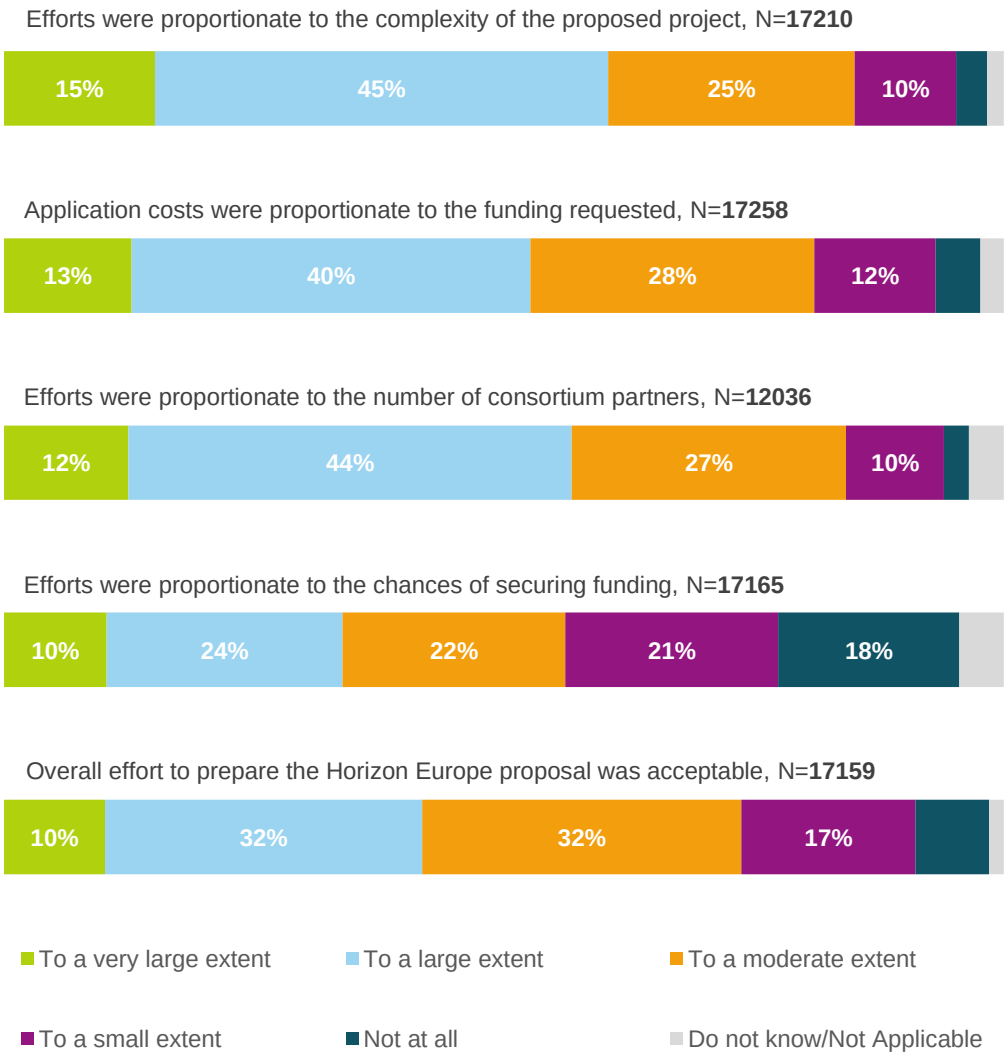


Figure 5 Views on the effort needed to prepare and submit the proposal

Programme beneficiaries and unsuccessful applicants. The option "The efforts needed were proportionate to the number of consortium partners involved" was not available in the ERC, MSCA and EIC Accelerator questionnaires.

*In your estimation, how many **person-days did you spend in preparing your proposal**?*

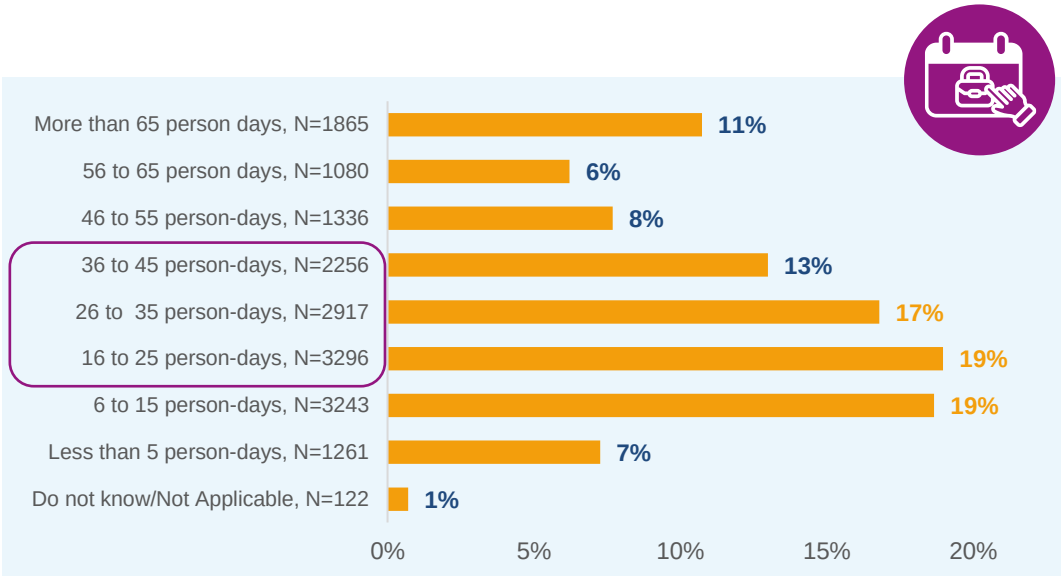


Figure 6 Estimation on the person-days spent to prepare proposal.

Programme beneficiaries and unsuccessful applicants.

*Did you receive any **support in your project application/preparation of proposal**?*

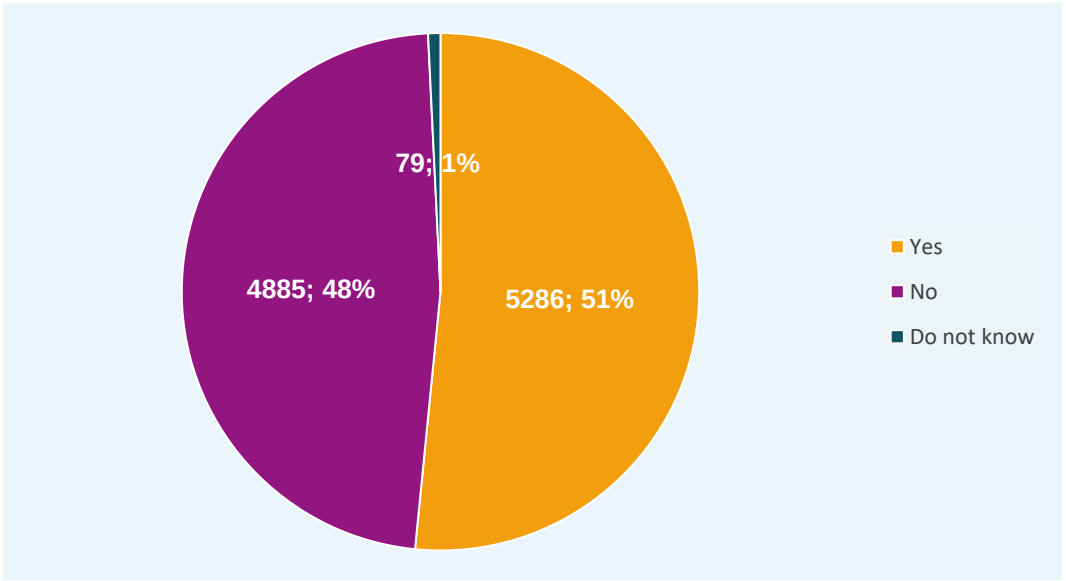


Figure 7 Support received in project application/preparation of proposal

Programme beneficiaries and unsuccessful applicants.

*Please specify **the type of support that you received***

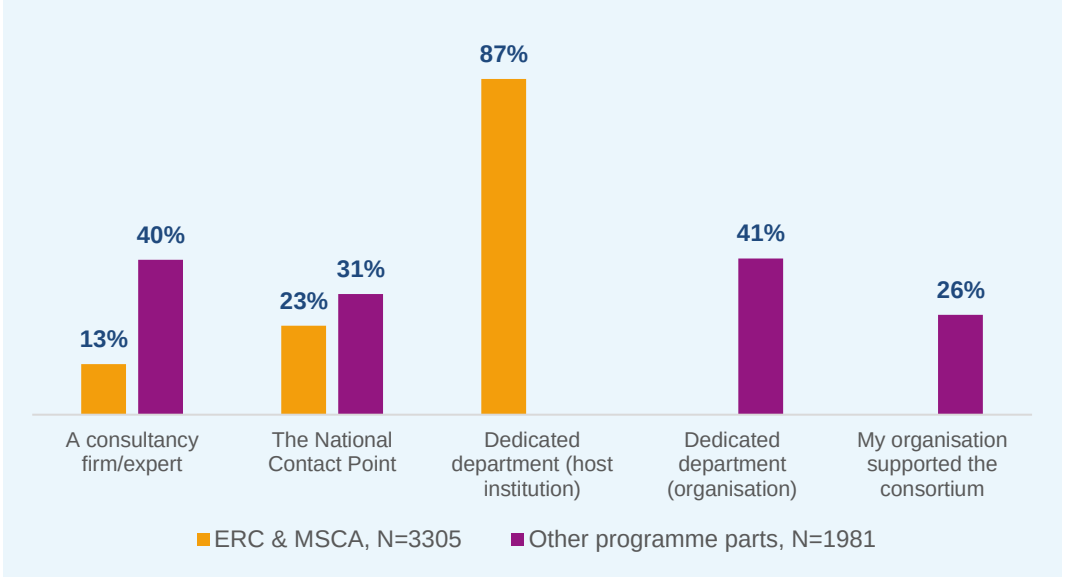


Figure 8 Type of support received

Programme beneficiaries and unsuccessful applicants answering that they received support in the application/preparation of their proposal. The option "My organisation supported the consortium was not available in the EIC Accelerator questionnaires. Multiple choice question.

*Would you agree or disagree with the following statements about **the administrative and management processes** in your project?*

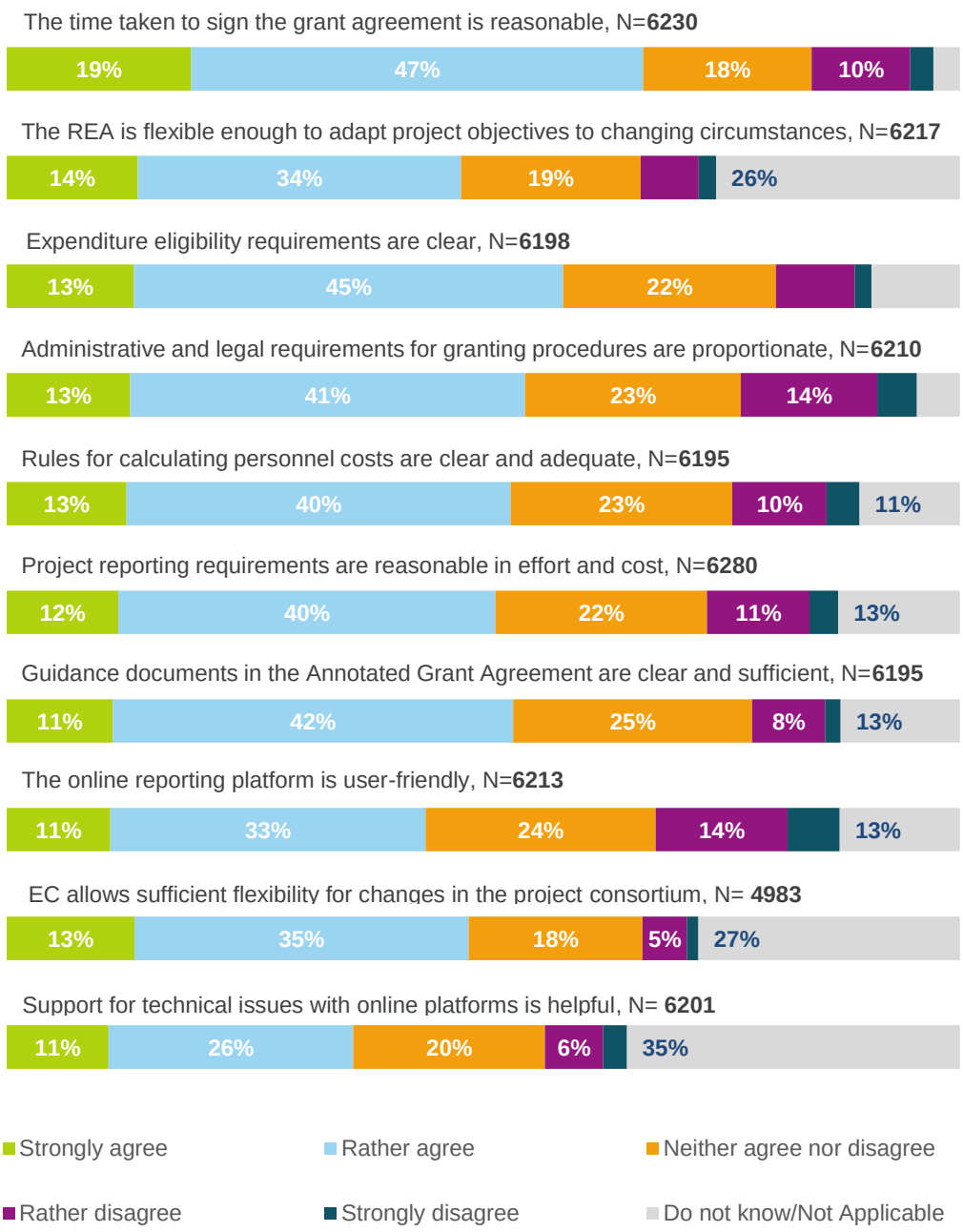


Figure 9 Views on the administrative and management processes

Programme beneficiaries. The option "The EC allows sufficient flexibility for changes in the project consortium" was not available in the ERC, MSCA and EIC Accelerator questionnaires.

*In your estimation, what is the percentage **share of your project budget spent on administrative tasks**?*

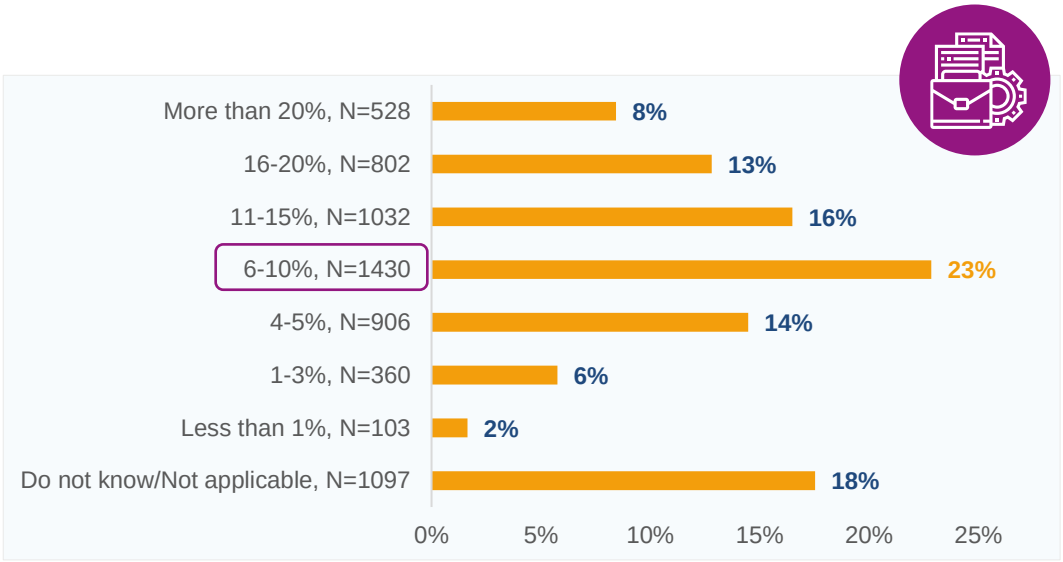


Figure 10 Estimation on share of project budget spent on administrative tasks

Programme beneficiaries.

Before your current Horizon Europe project, have you ***participated in Horizon 2020***?

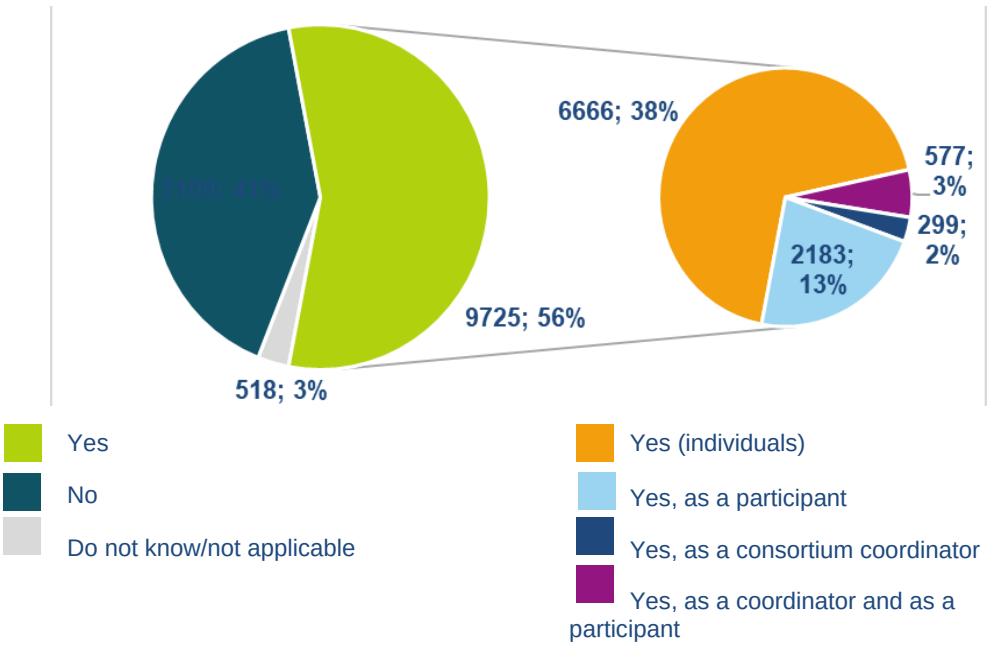


Figure 11 Previous participation in Horizon 2020

Programme beneficiaries and unsuccessful applicants.

Based on your overall FP experience, would you agree or disagree with the following statements on the ***project's lifecycle processes in Horizon Europe, compared to Horizon 2020***?

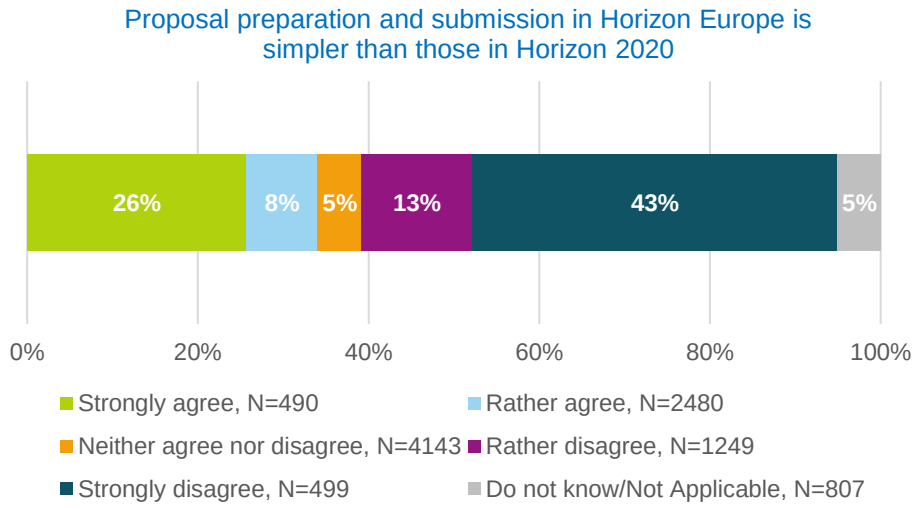


Figure 12 Views on proposal preparation and submission in Horizon Europe, compared to Horizon 2020

Programme beneficiaries and unsuccessful applicants that participated in Horizon 2020.

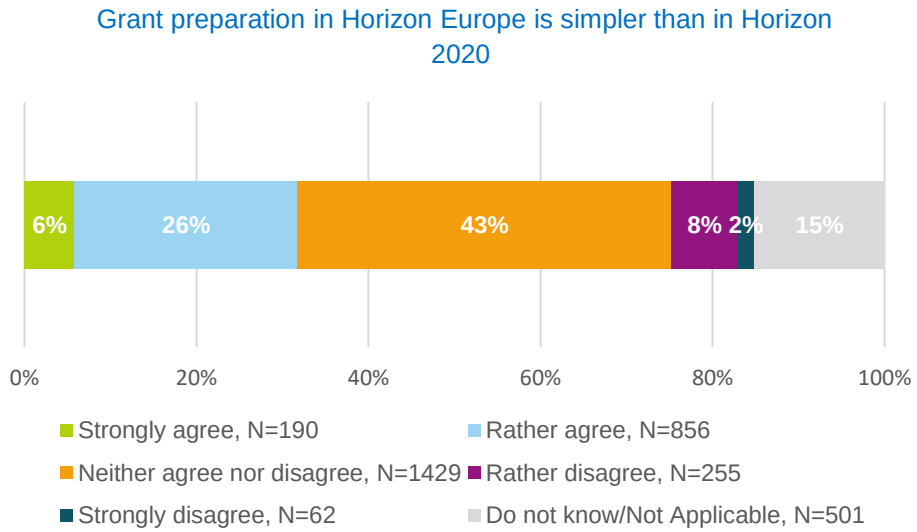


Figure 13 Views on grant preparation in Horizon Europe, compared to Horizon 2020

Programme beneficiaries that participated in Horizon 2020.

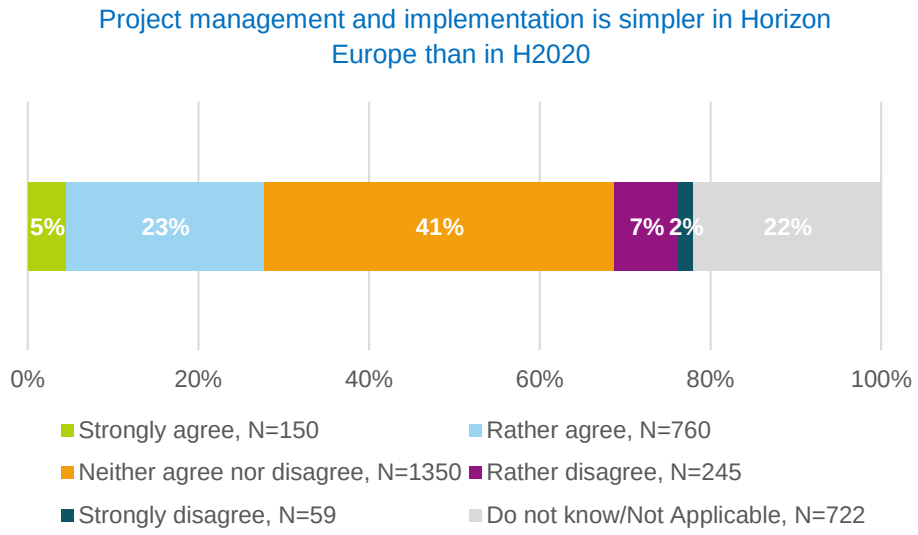


Figure 14 Views on project management and implementation in Horizon Europe, compared to Horizon 2020

Programme beneficiaries that participated in Horizon 2020.

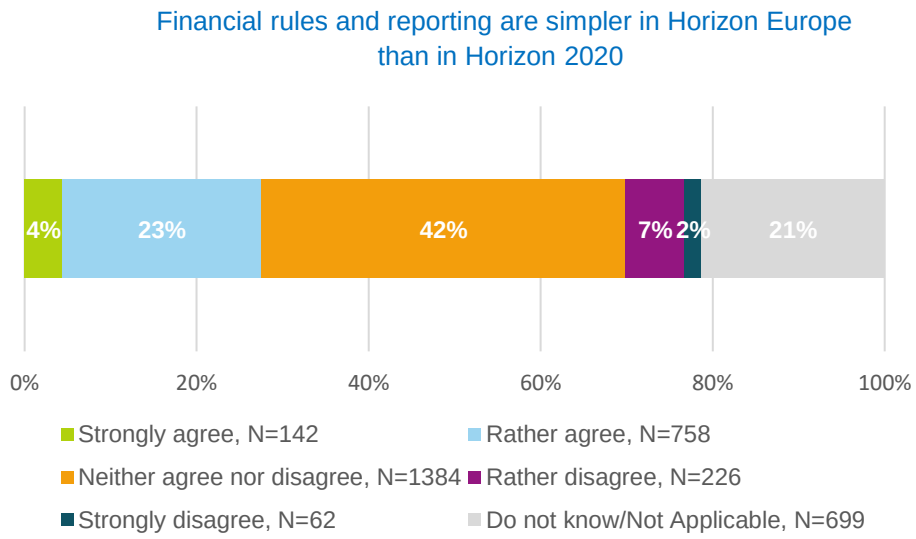


Figure 15 Views on financial rules and reporting in Horizon Europe, compared to Horizon 2020

Programme beneficiaries that participated in Horizon 2020.

*To what extent do you agree with the following statements on **lump-sum funding** in your Horizon Europe project?*

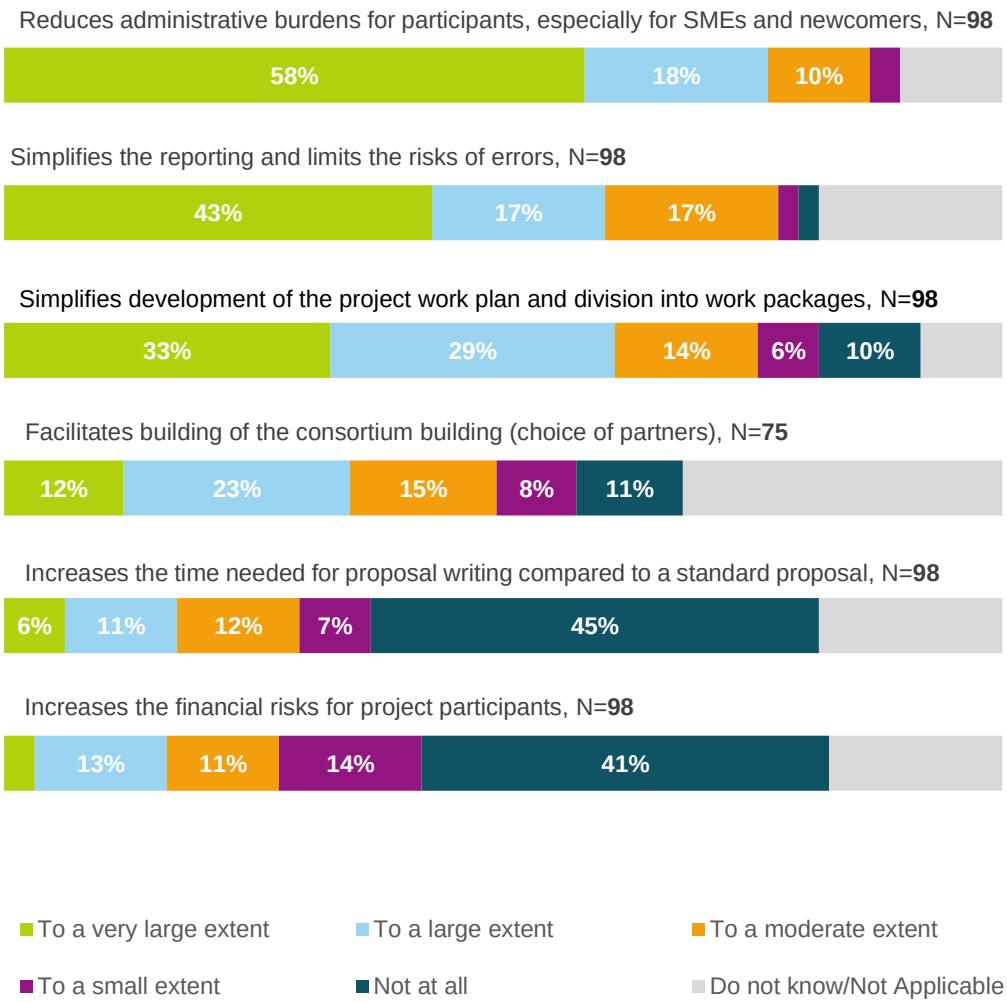


Figure 16 Views on lump-sum funding

Programme beneficiaries, excluding MSCA and EIC Accelerator participants.

2.2. Internal and external coherence (synergies)

*Are there any activities planned in your project that are implemented in **collaboration with projects funded under other Horizon Europe programme parts or clusters**?*

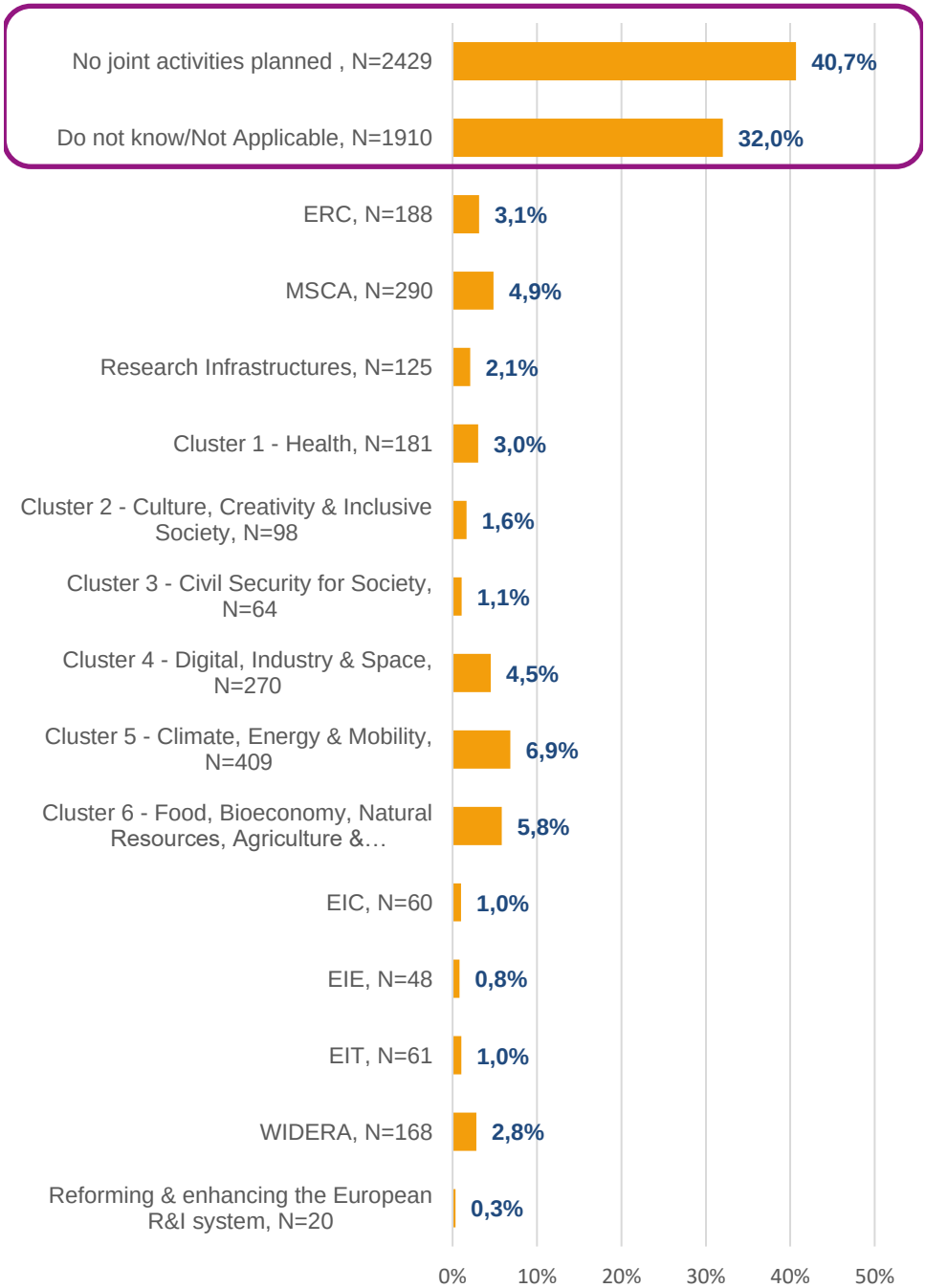


Figure 17 Collaboration with projects funded under other Horizon Europe programme parts or clusters

Programme beneficiaries. Multiple choice question.

*Would you agree or disagree that the **Technology Readiness Level scale** adequately captures the market maturity level of the project results?*

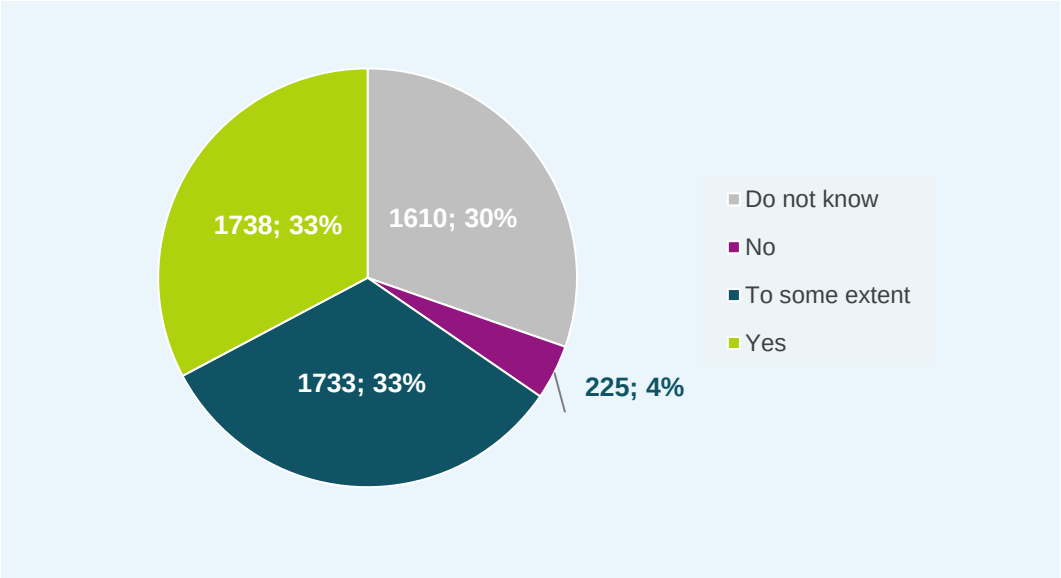


Figure 18 Views on market maturity using the Technology Readiness Level scale

Programme beneficiaries (N= 5306)

*Is your project a **continuation of research activities** carried out under previous/other funding schemes?*

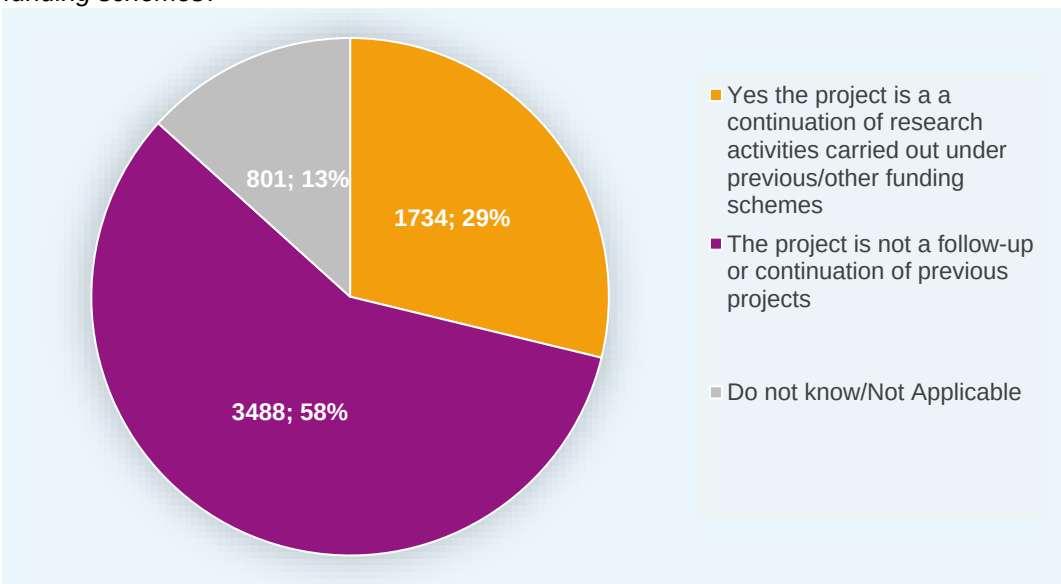


Figure 19 Project continuation from previous funding scheme

Programme beneficiaries (N= 6023)

Please specify the other/previous source of funding

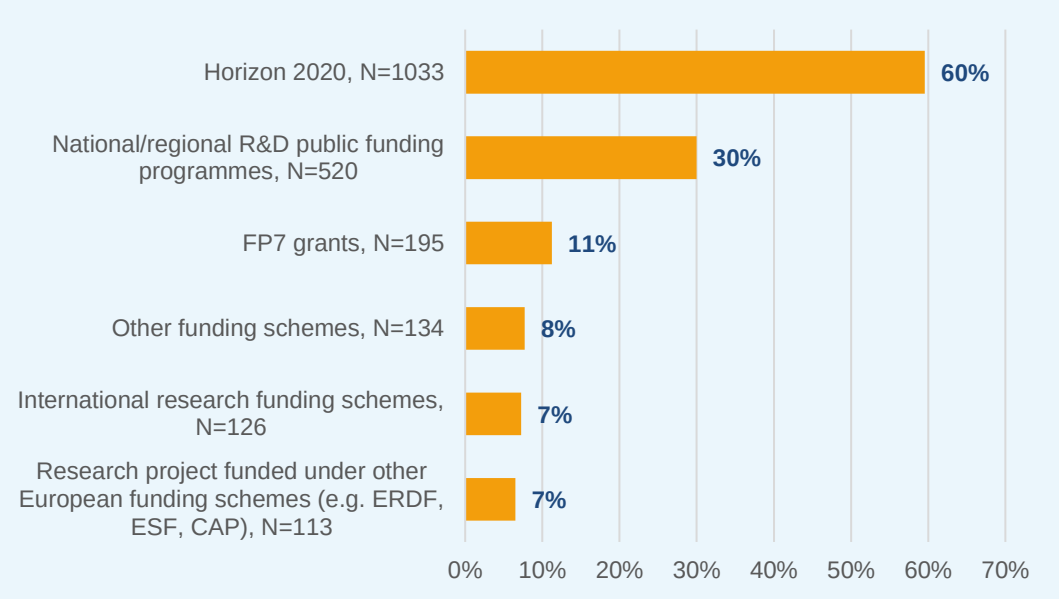


Figure 20 Previous sources of project funding

Project beneficiaries (N=1734). Multiple choice question.

*Have you **applied for any additional funding** for the research/activities addressed in your project?*

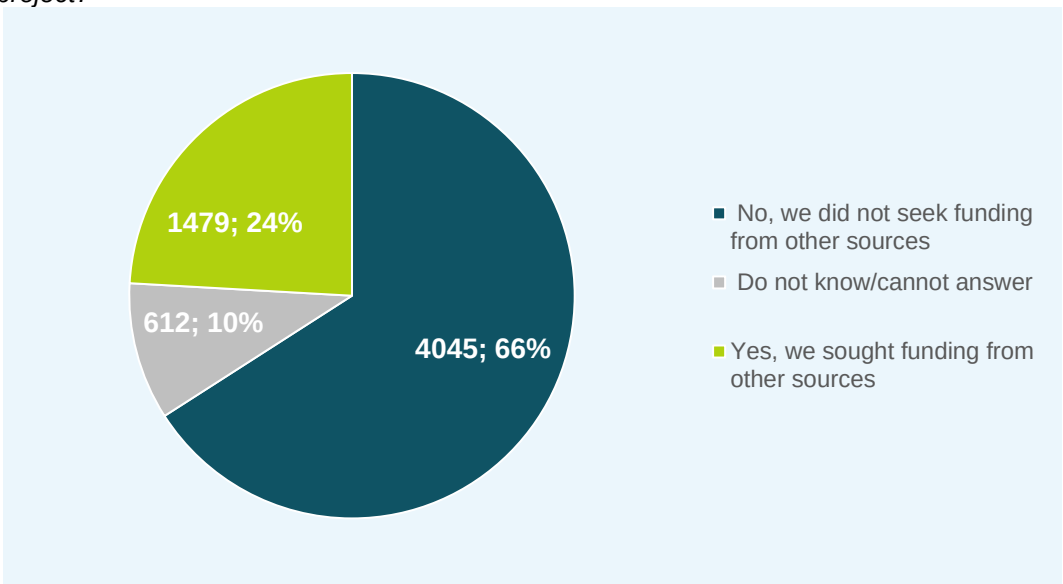


Figure 21 Application for additional funding for project activities

Programme beneficiaries (N=6136)

*Please specify **the alternative source of funding** you applied for.*

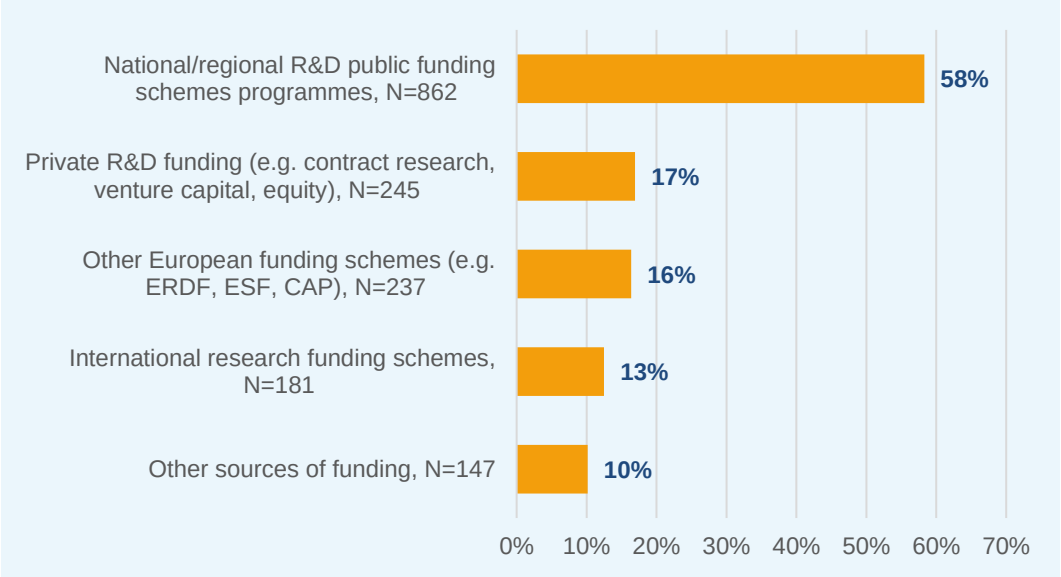


Figure 22 Alternative sources of applied funding

Only programme beneficiaries applying for additional funding sources (24% of respondents). Multiple choice questions.

*Have you already received the decision regarding this **additional funding**?*

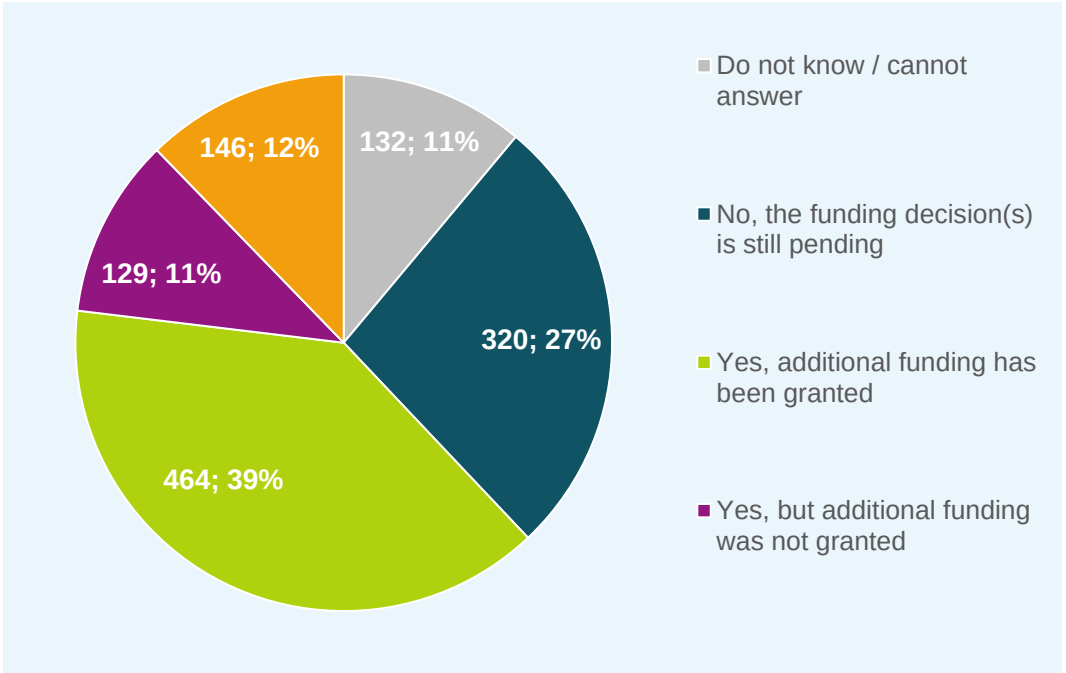


Figure 23 Decision status on additional funding application

Programme beneficiaries, applying for additional funding sources excluding EIC Accelerator participants

2.3. Relevance

*In your opinion, to what extent does Horizon Europe provide **sufficient funding opportunities** in the following areas?*

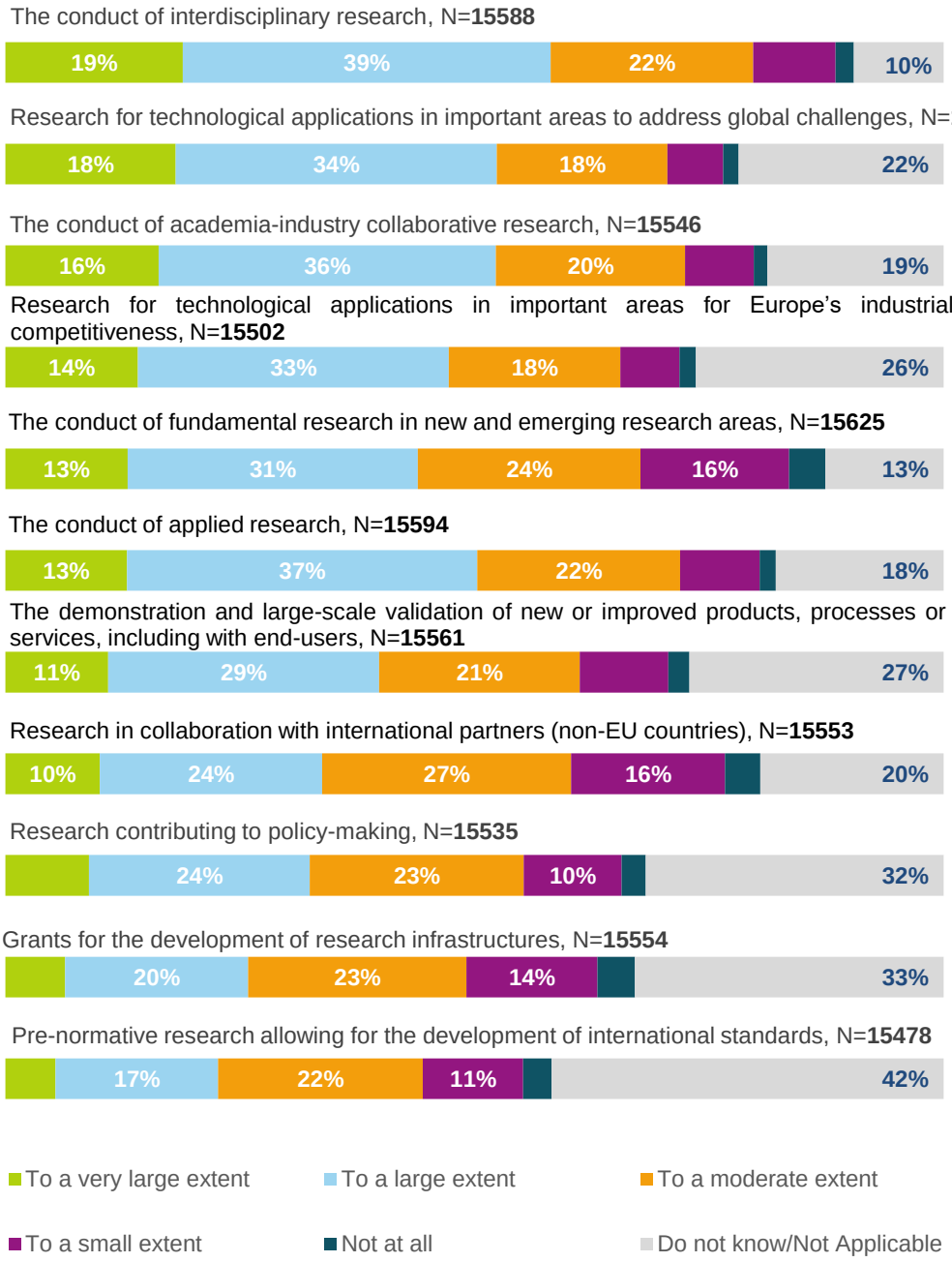


Figure 24 Views on the sufficiency of funding opportunities in key areas under Horizo Europe.

Programme beneficiaries and unsuccessful applicants. Multiple choice question.

*To what extent the opportunities provided by your project **respond to your following needs**?*

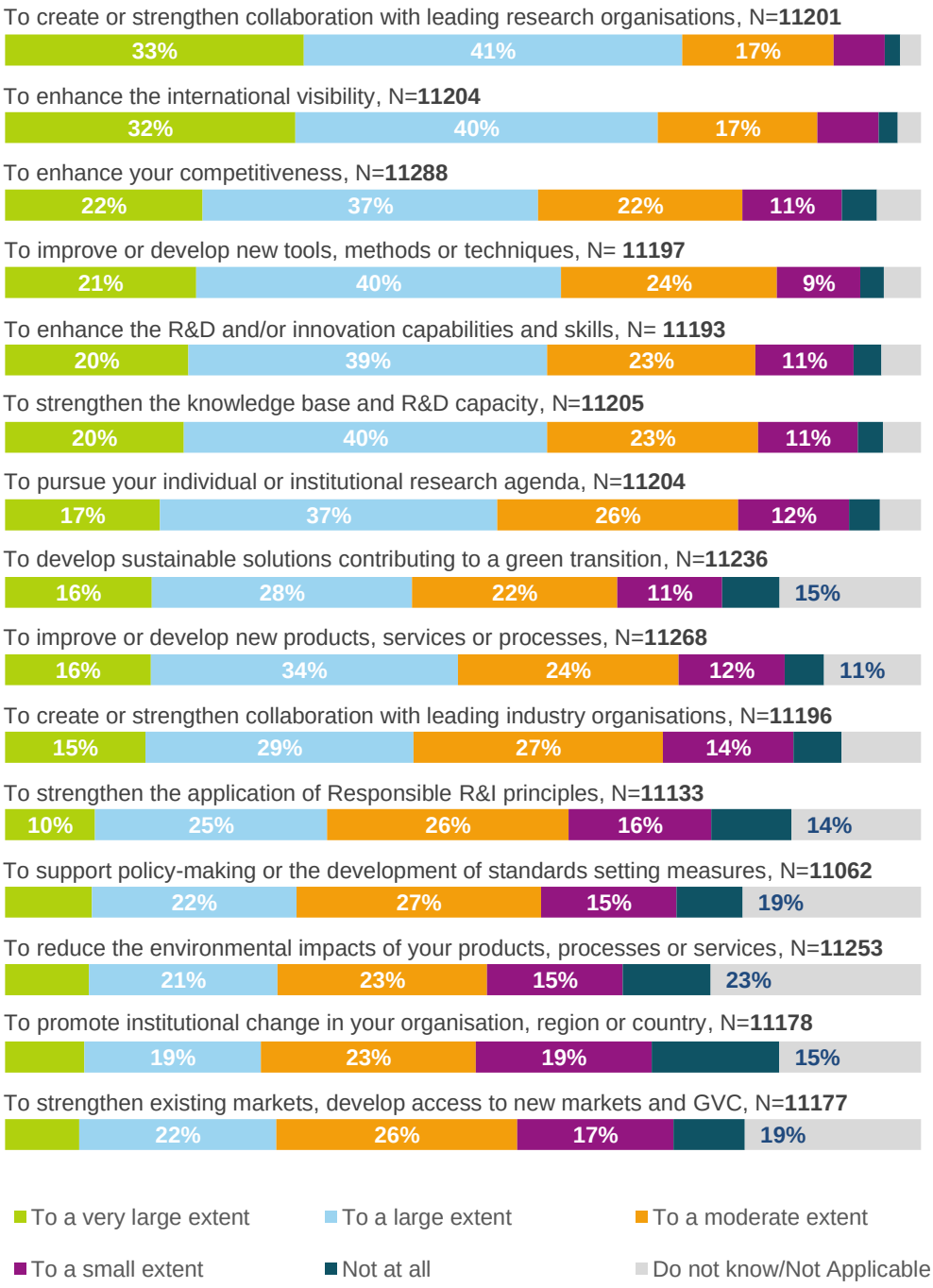


Figure 25 Extent to which project opportunities address participants' specific needs.

Programme beneficiaries and unsuccessful applicants, excluding MSCA, ERC. Multiple choice question.

*To what extent the opportunities provided by your **ERC or MSCA project respond to your following needs**?*

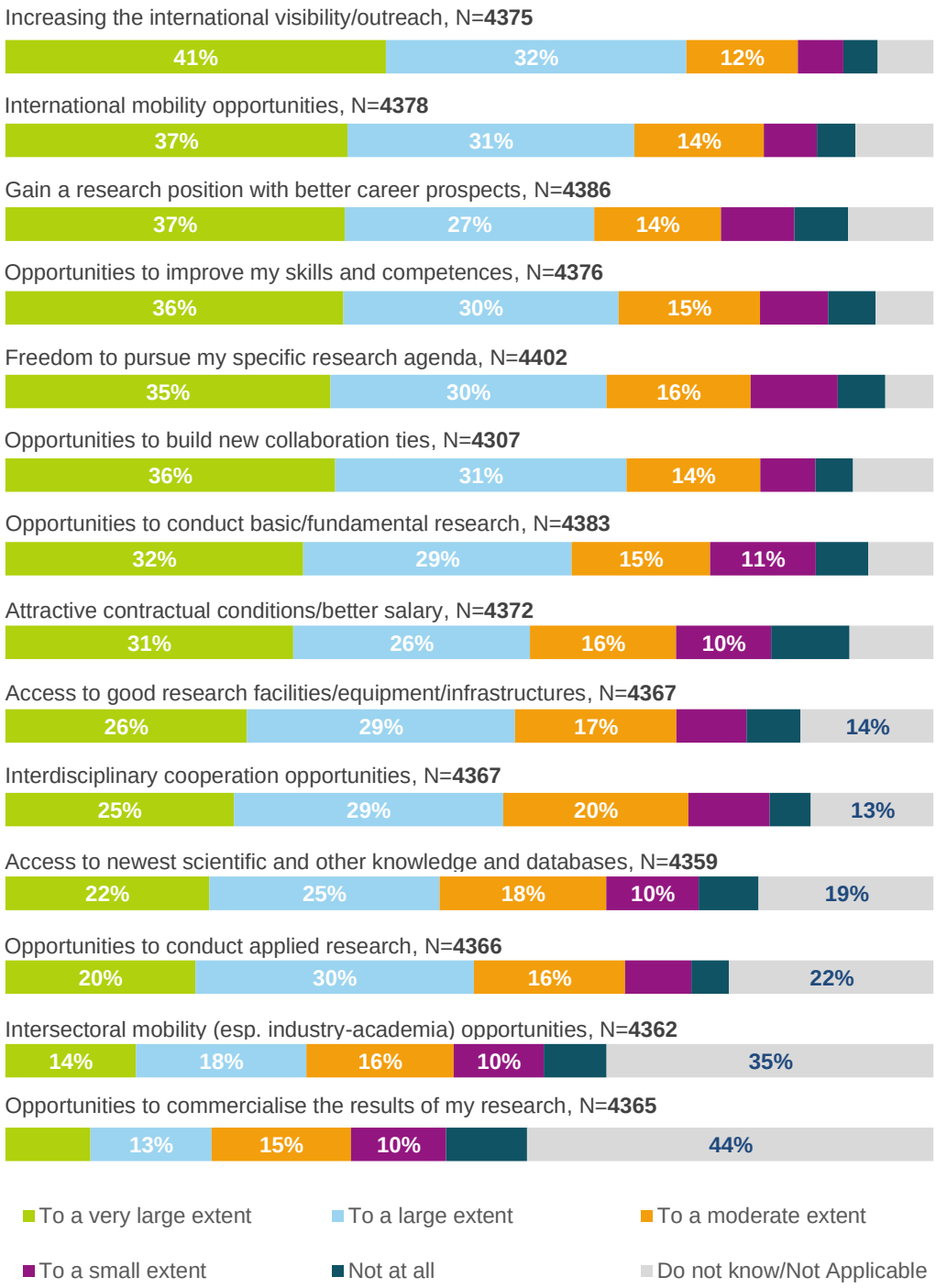


Figure 26 Extent to which ERC or MSCA project opportunities address specific needs.

ERC and MSCA programme beneficiaries and unsuccessful applicants. Multiple choice question.

*Do you use/integrate **Artificial Intelligence (AI)-based tools & methods** as part of your project?*

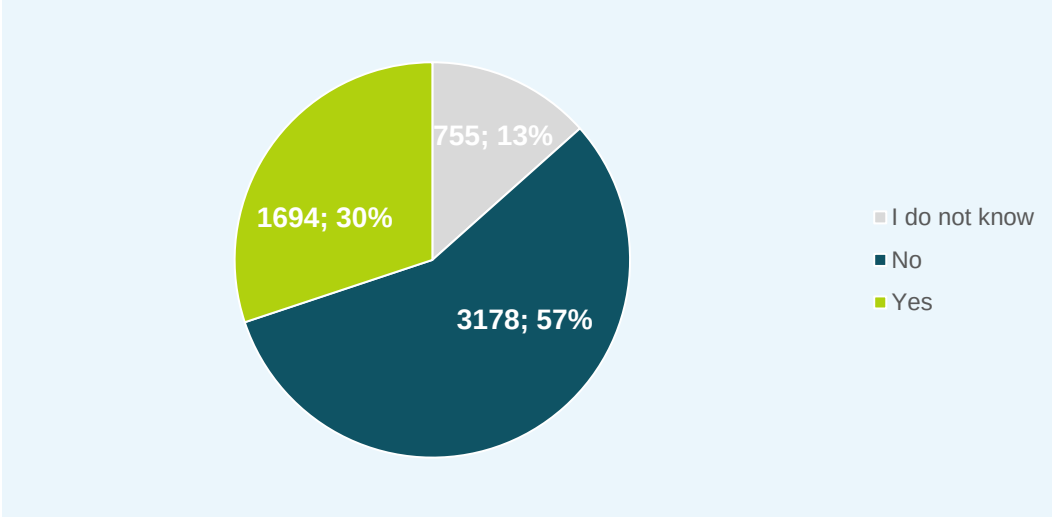


Figure 27 Use/integration of Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools and methods in projects

*To what extent do you make use/integrate **AI-based tools or methods** in your project?*

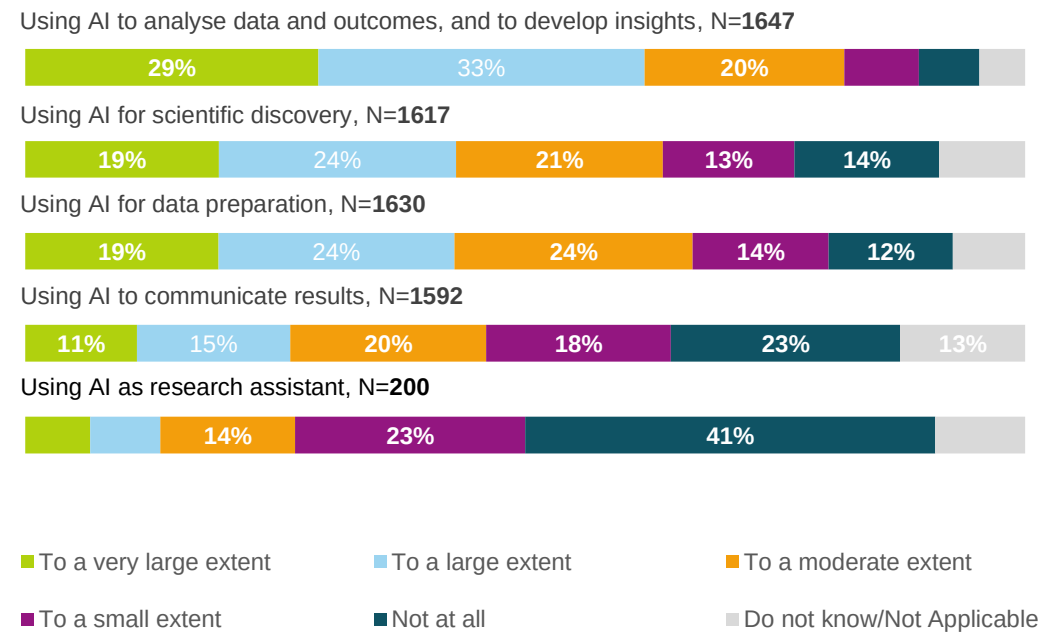


Figure 28 Extent of use/integration of Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools and methods in projects

*Which of the following **green policy measures**, if any, have you applied or are you considering applying while implementing your project?*

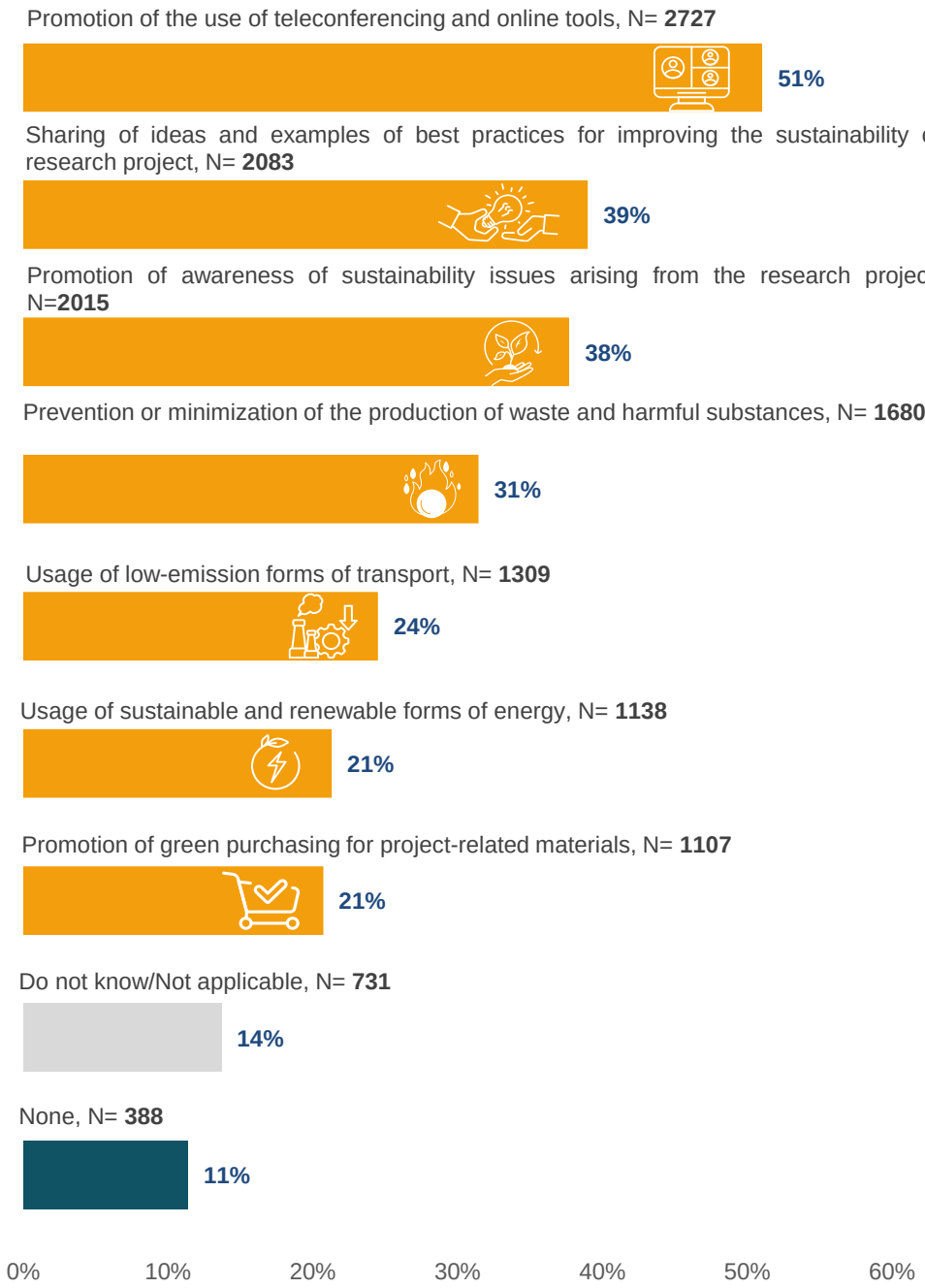


Figure 29 Green policy measures applied or considered in project implementation

Programme beneficiaries, excluding EIC Accelerator participants. Multiple choice question. The option "None" was not available in questionnaire to project beneficiaries in CL 5 and 6.

The following chart presents the results of the above question, disaggregated by instrument

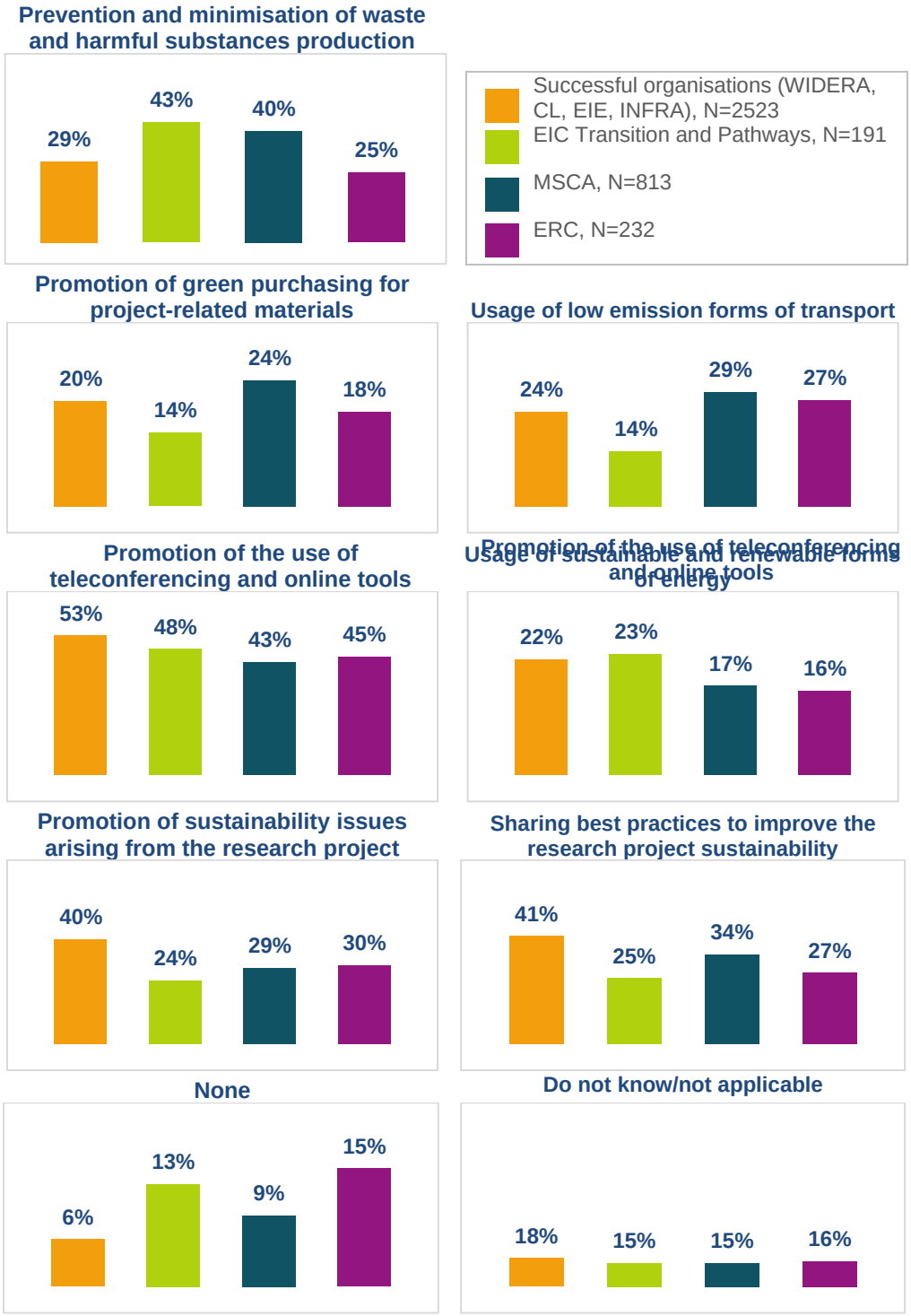


Figure 30 Green policy measures applied or considered in project implementation, disaggregated by instrument

*Which type of **training** have you received or plan to receive in the framework of your MSCA project?*

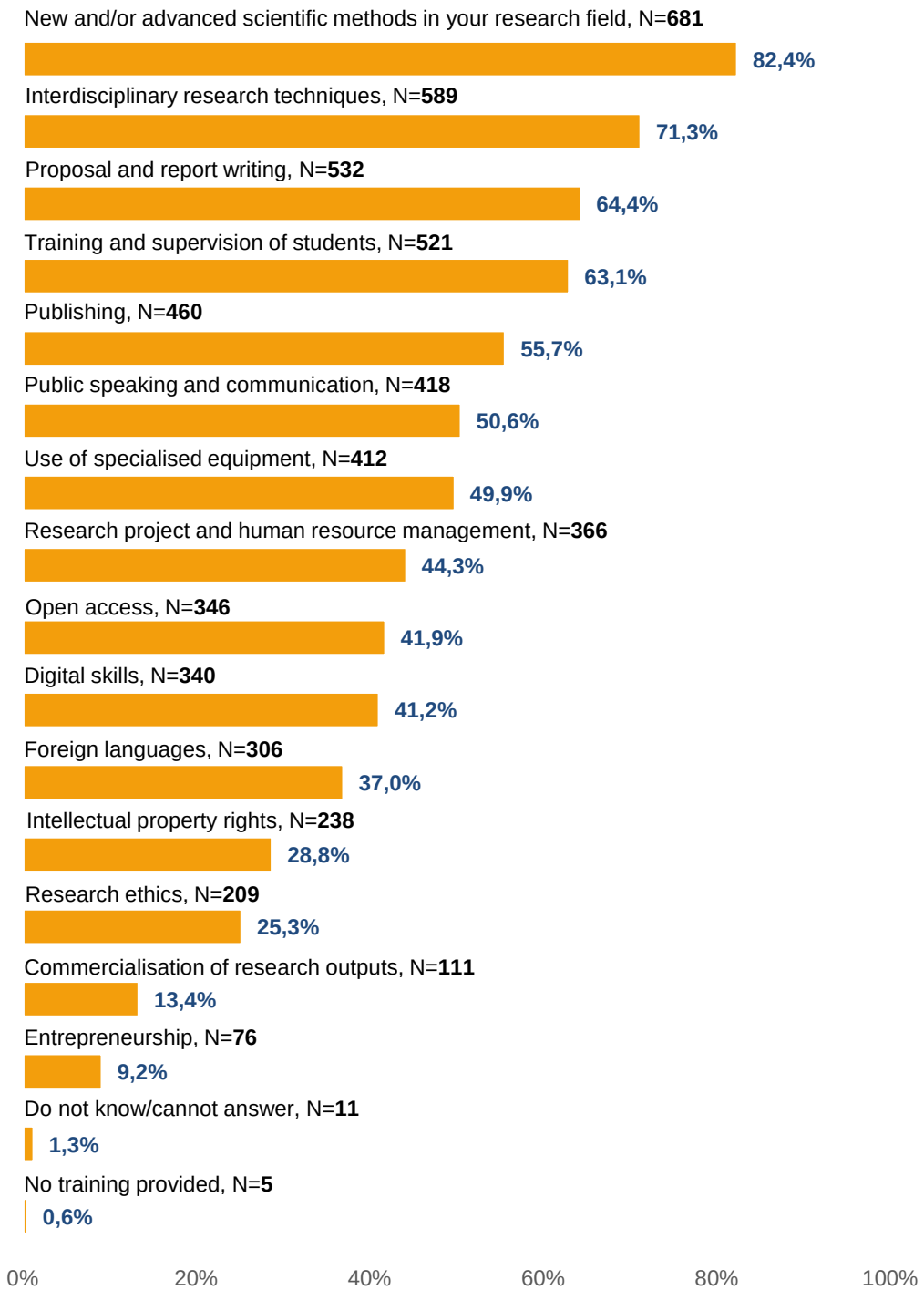


Figure 31 Types of training received or planned in the framework of MSCA projects

MSCA programme beneficiaries. Multiple choice question.

*To what extent, if at all, will the participation in your project have an impact on **development of your skills** in the following areas?*

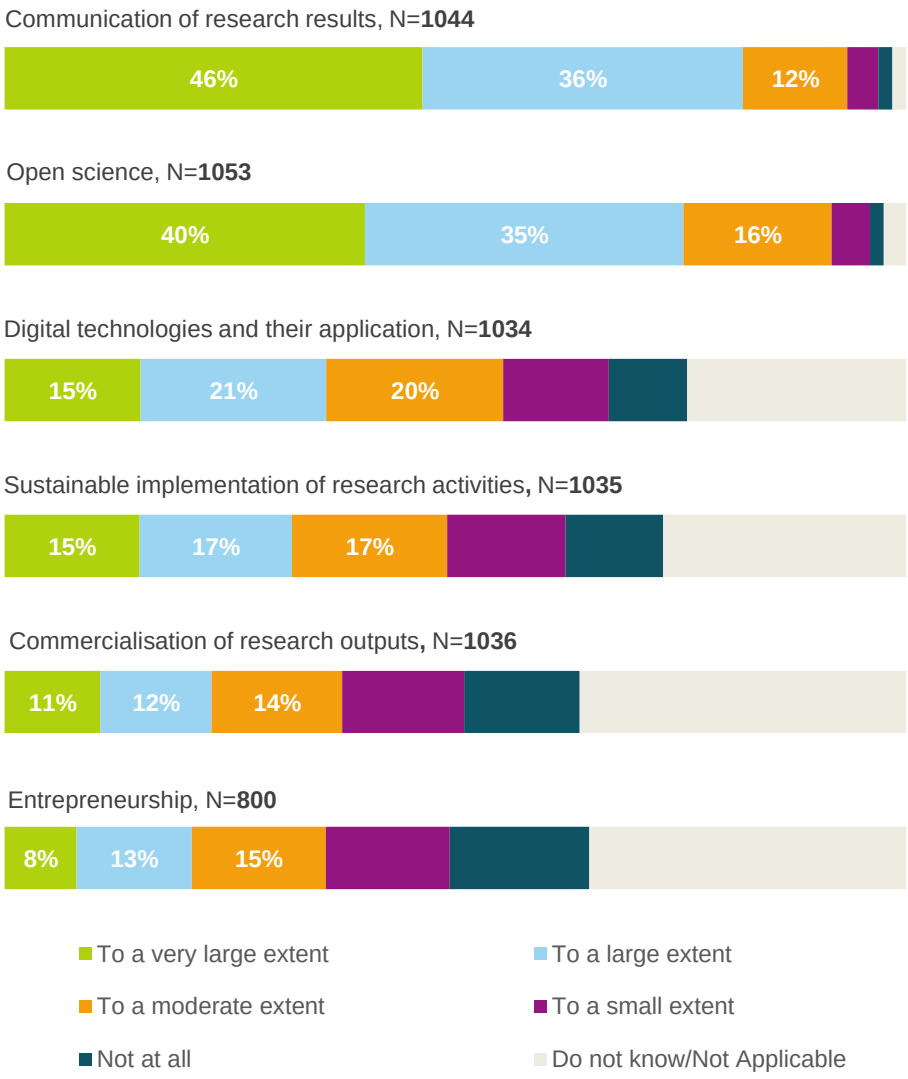


Figure 32 Extent of project participation's impact on skill development

MSCA and ERC programme beneficiaries. The "Entrepreneurship" option was not available in the ERC questionnaire. Multiple choice question.

*Based on your experience with the **host organisation**, to what extent do you agree with the following statements?*

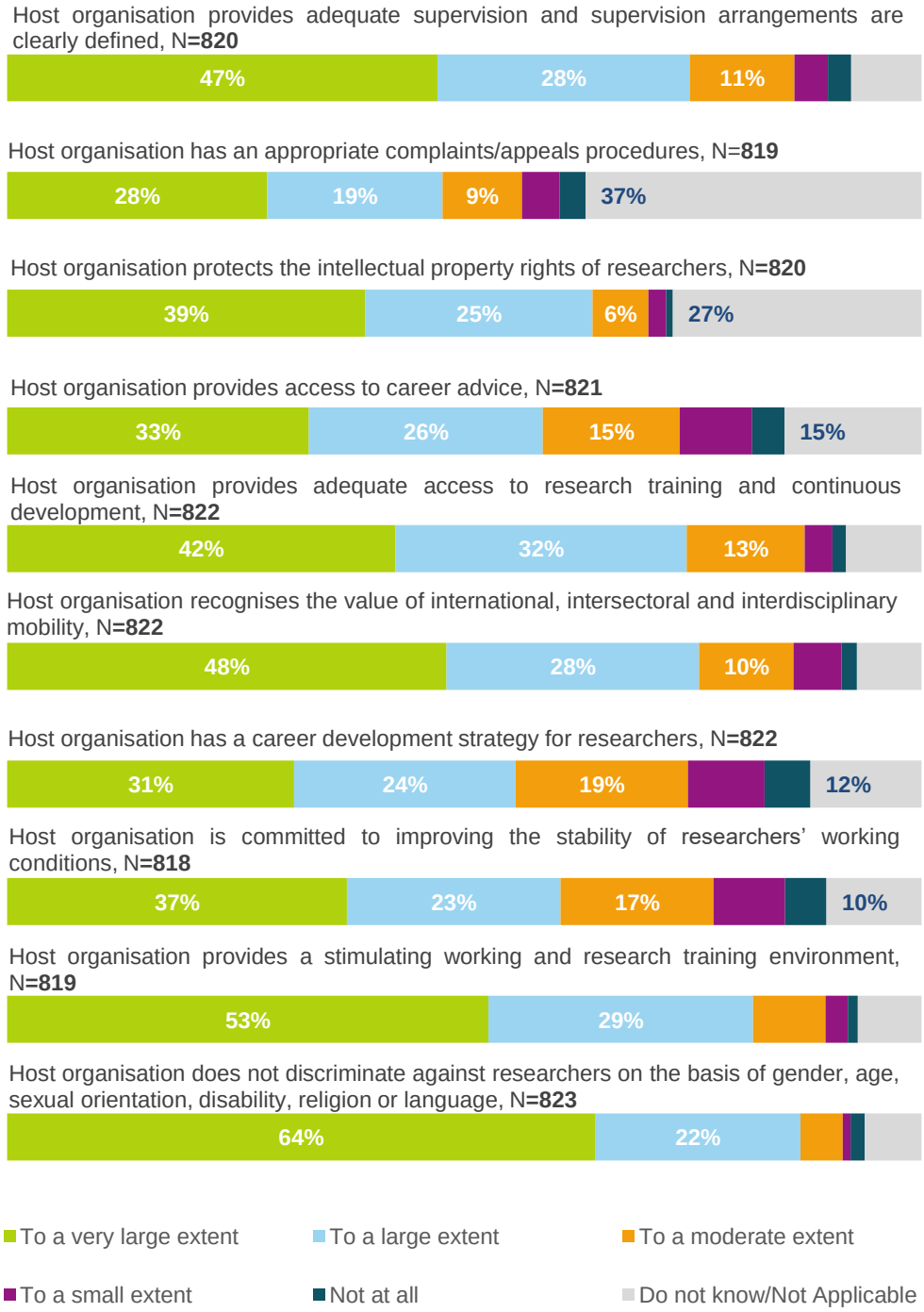


Figure 33 Views about host organisations

MSCA programme beneficiaries. Multiple choice question.

*In your opinion, to what extent does **EIC Accelerator provide sufficient funding opportunities** in the following areas?*

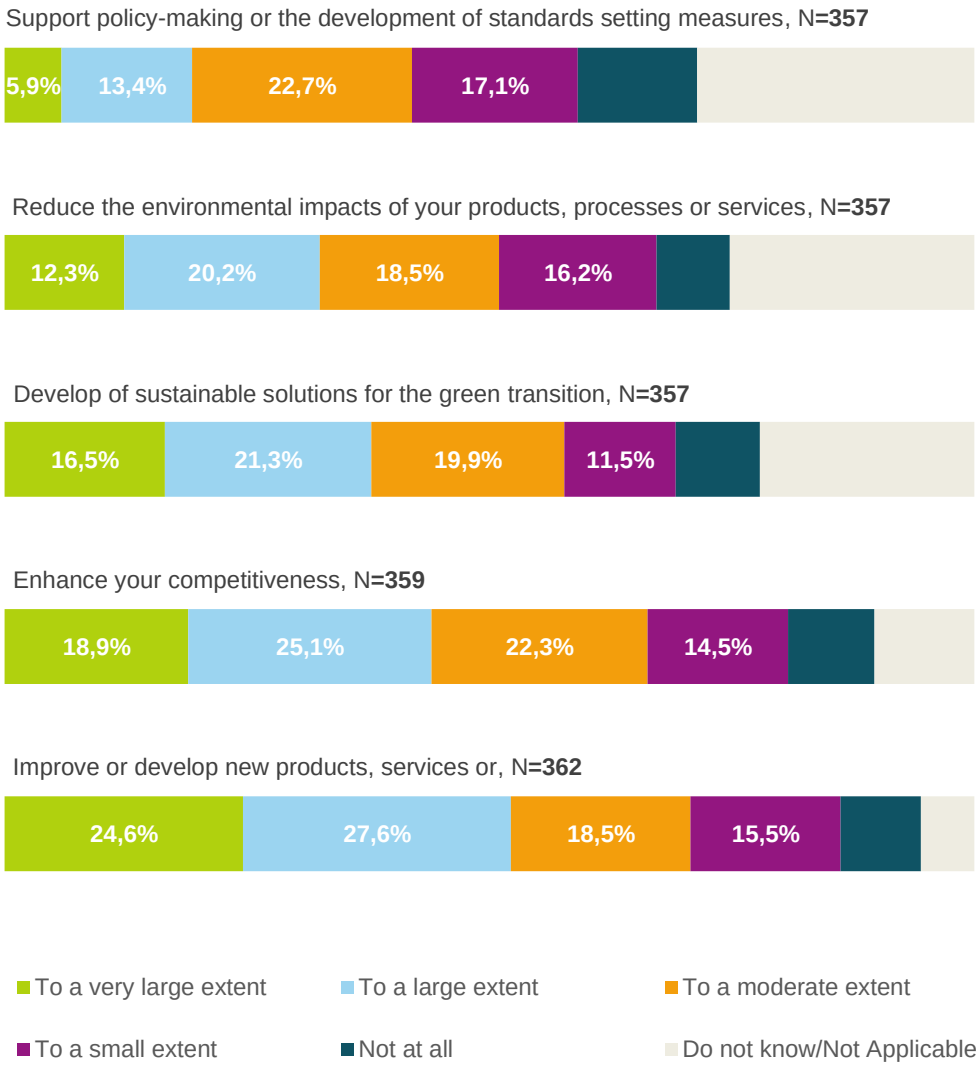


Figure 34 Views on the sufficiency of funding opportunities in key areas under EIC Accelerator

EIC Accelerator unsuccessful applicants. Multiple choice question.

***Why did you apply** for the EIC Fund?*

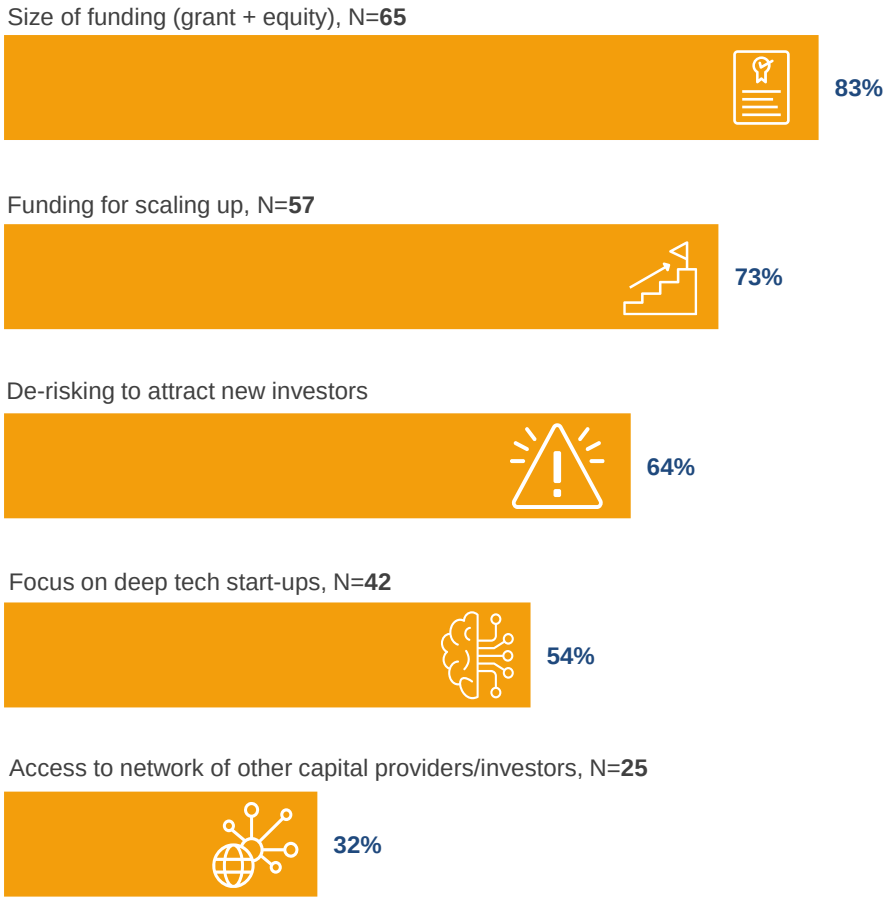


Figure 35 Reasons for applying for the EIC Fund

EIC Accelerator programme beneficiaries. Multiple choice question.

*Please choose the combination that best describes the **core asset of your EIC Accelerator project**?*

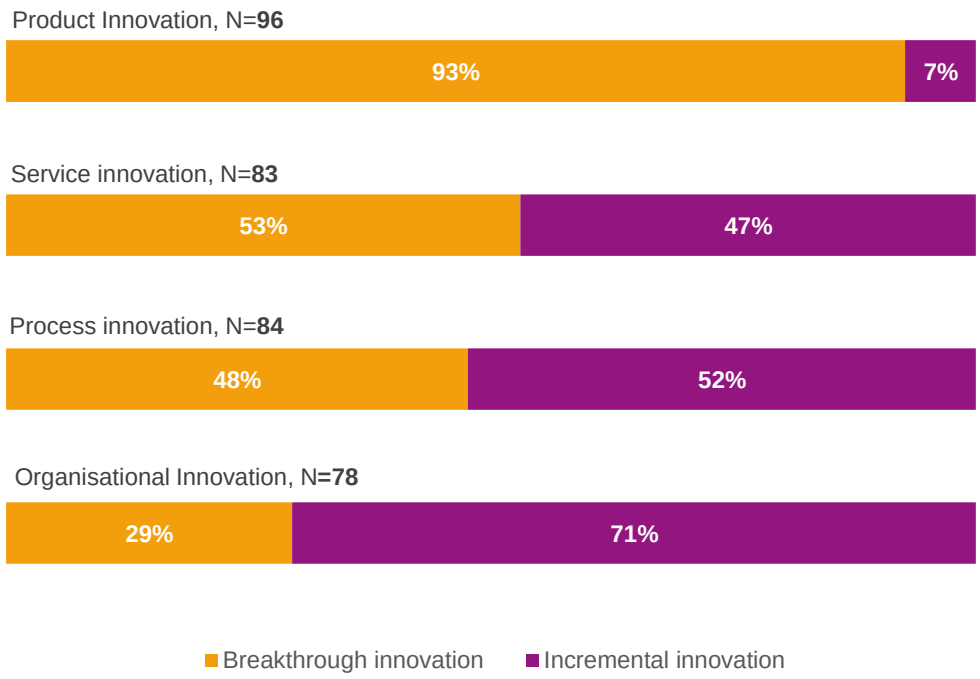


Figure 36 Core asset combination of EIC Accelerator projects

EIC Accelerator programme beneficiaries. Multiple choice question.

*To what extent did EIC Accelerator **help remove the following barriers** to progressing your innovation?*

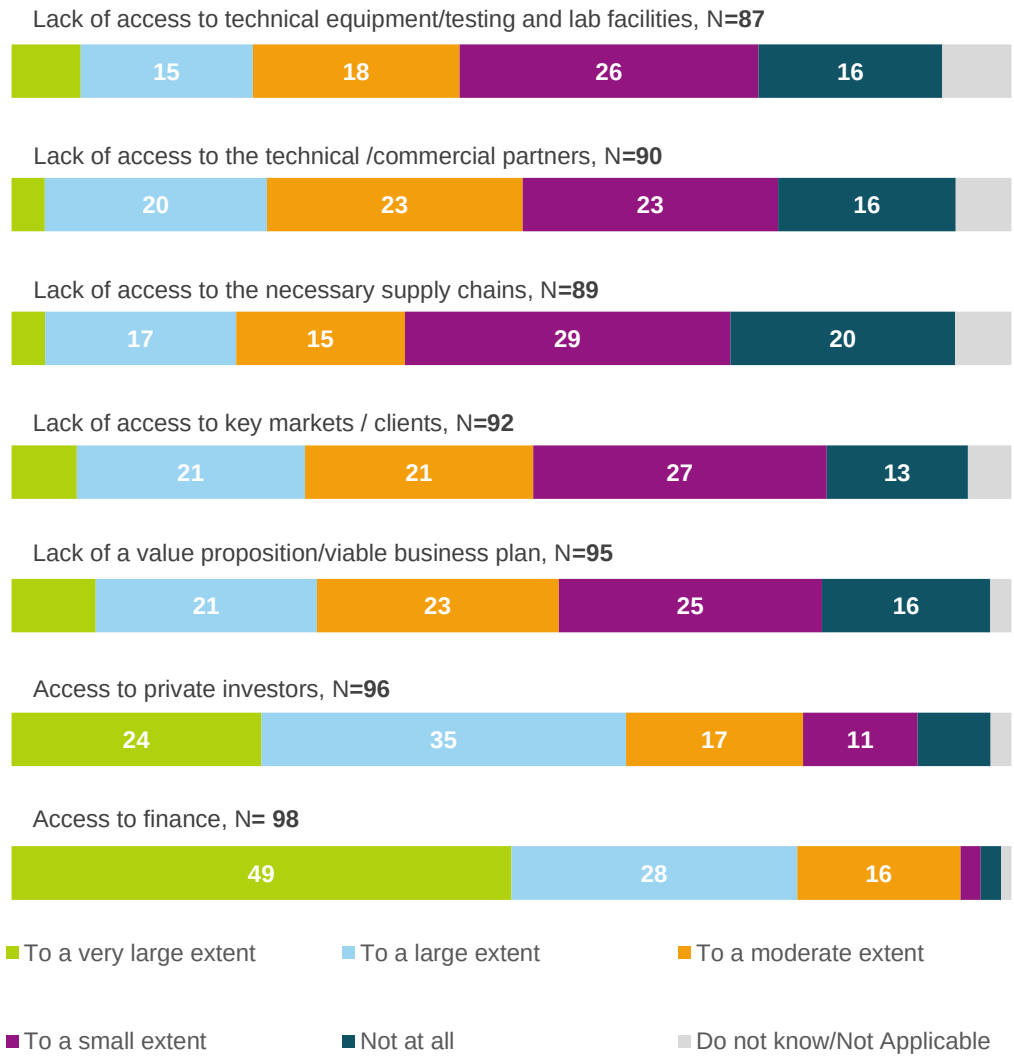


Figure 37 Views on the extent to which EIC Accelerator helped remove barriers to innovation progress

EIC Accelerator programme beneficiaries. Multiple choice question.

2.4. Obstacles and challenges encountered during Horizon Europe project

*To what extent have the following barriers constituted **challenges** when carrying out your project?*

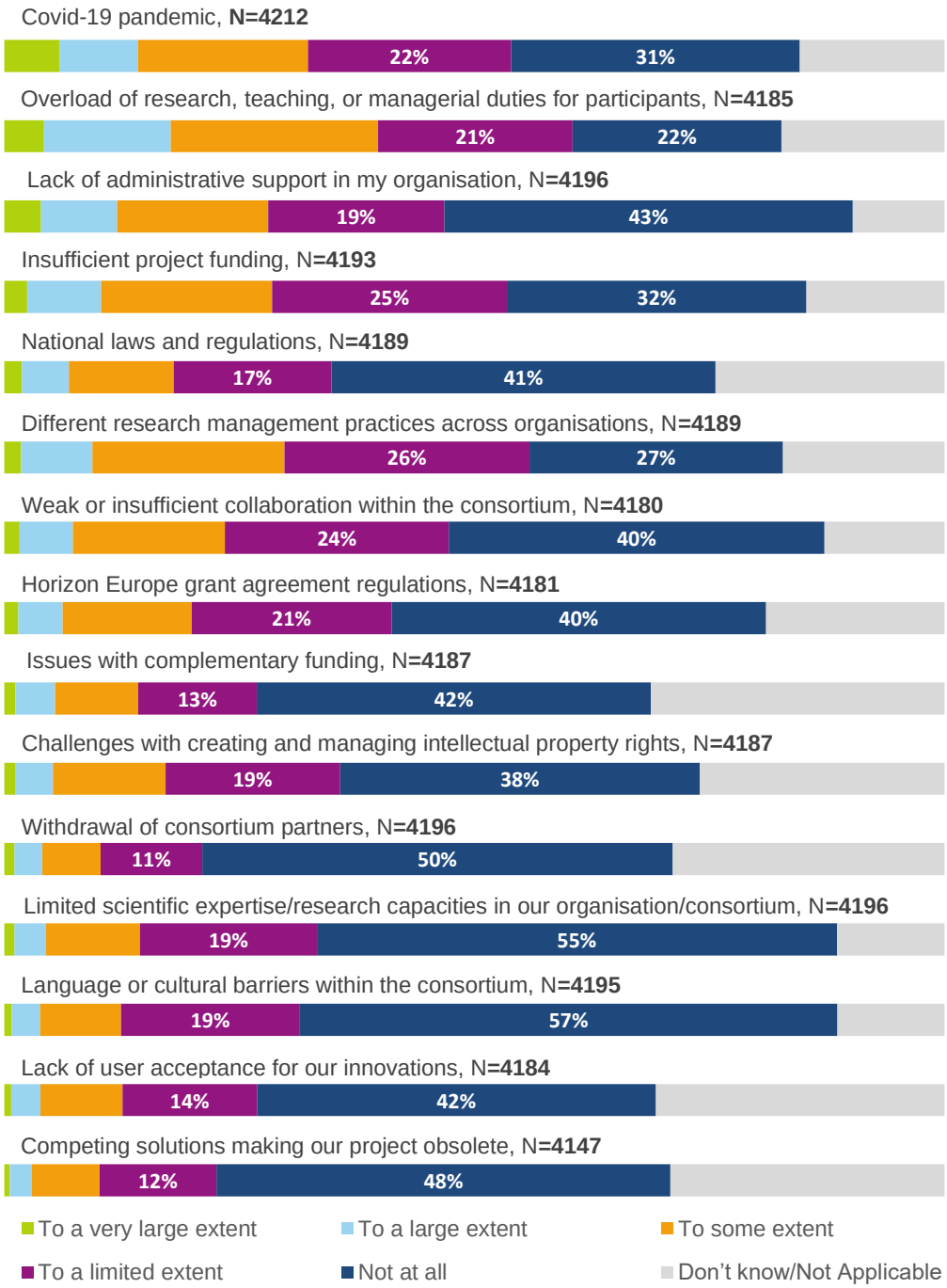


Figure 38 Views on barriers that constituted challenges

Programme beneficiaries, excluding MSCA, ERC and EIC Accelerator participants. Multiple choice question.

*To what extent the following factors facilitate the **application of digital tools** in your research project?*

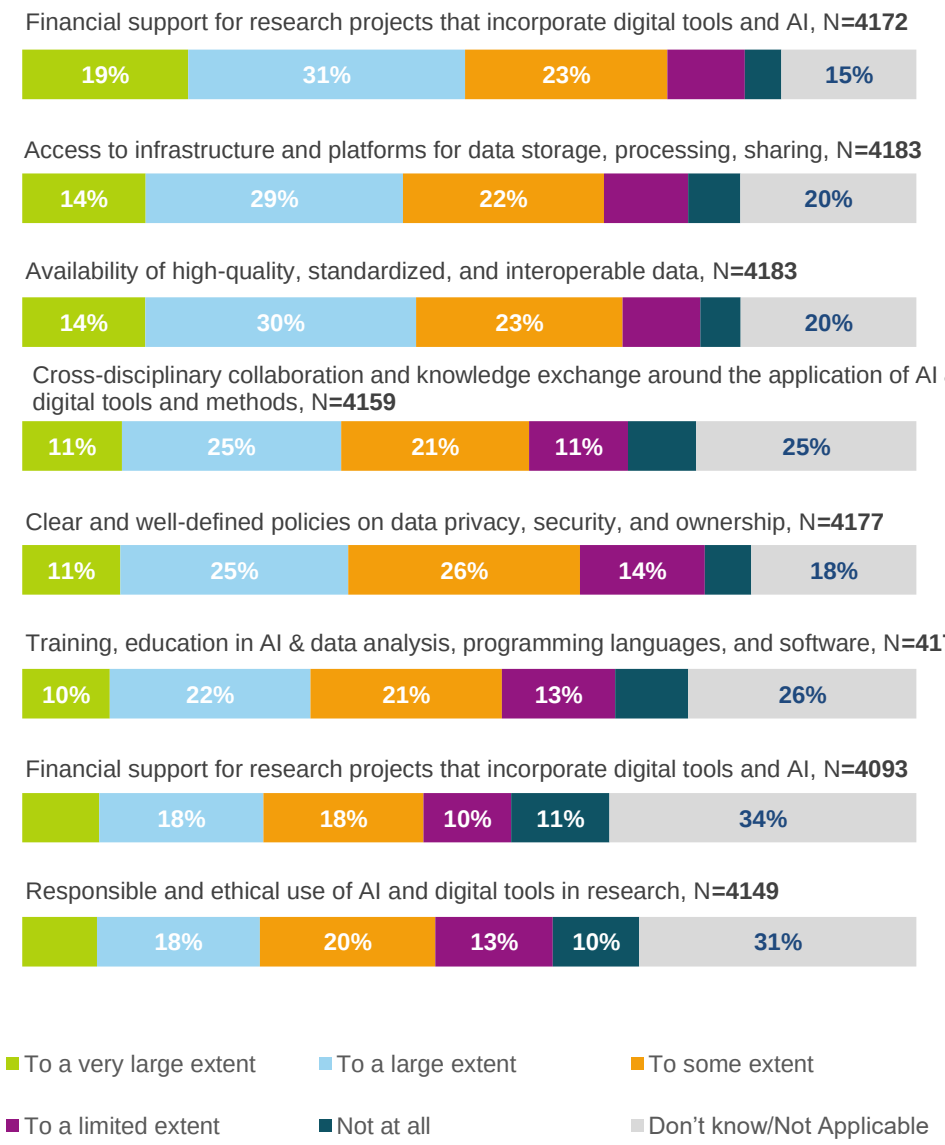


Figure 39 Views on factors that facilitated the application of digital tools in research projects

Programme beneficiaries, excluding MSCA, ERC and EIC Accelerator participants. Multiple choice question.

*Have you faced the following **obstacles** during the participation in your project?*

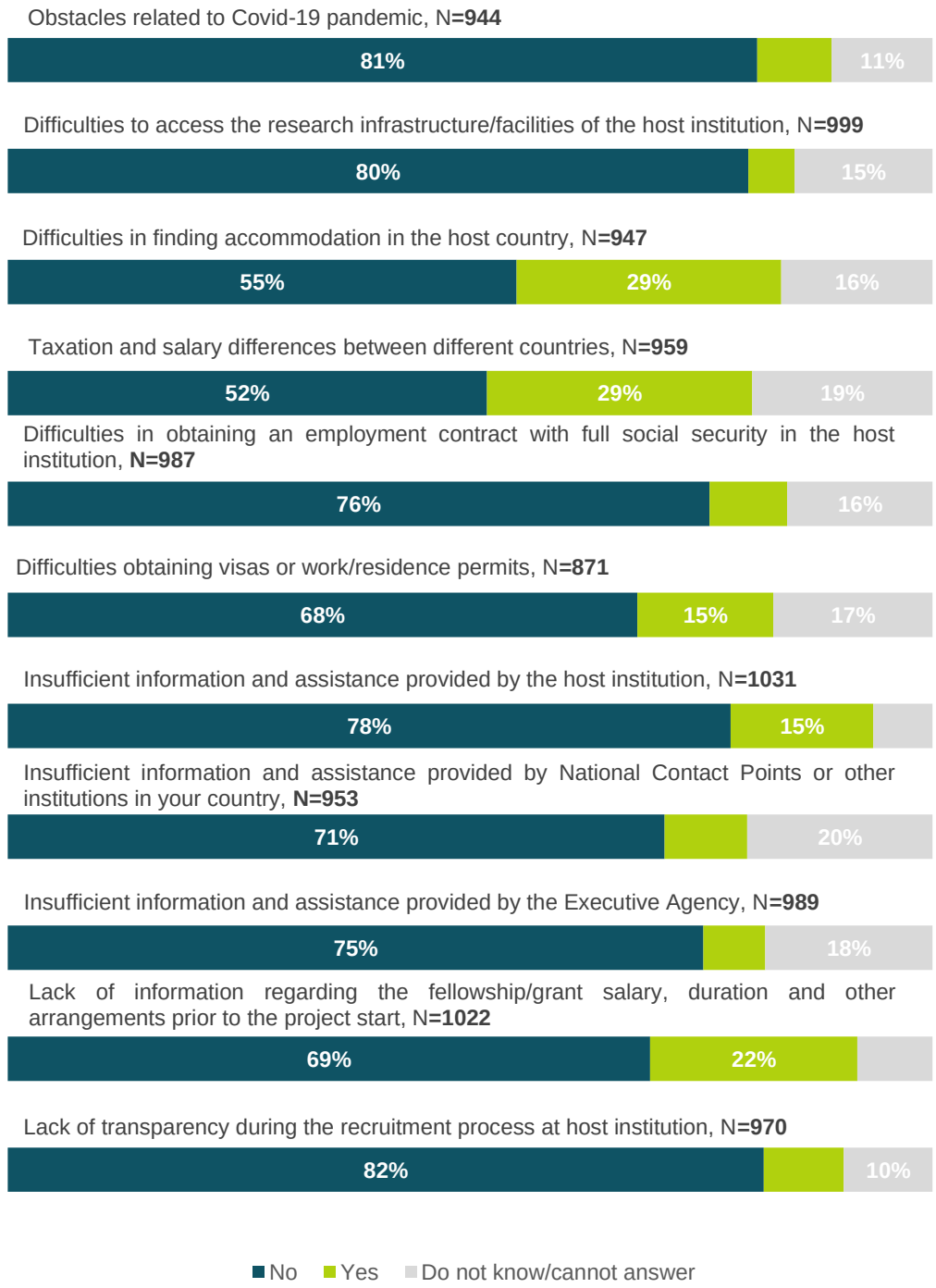


Figure 40 Obstacles faced during project participation

MSCA and ERC programme beneficiaries. Multiple choice question.

2.5. Dissemination, exploitation and communication of results

*Are there any **exploitation activities** foreseen as a part of your project?*

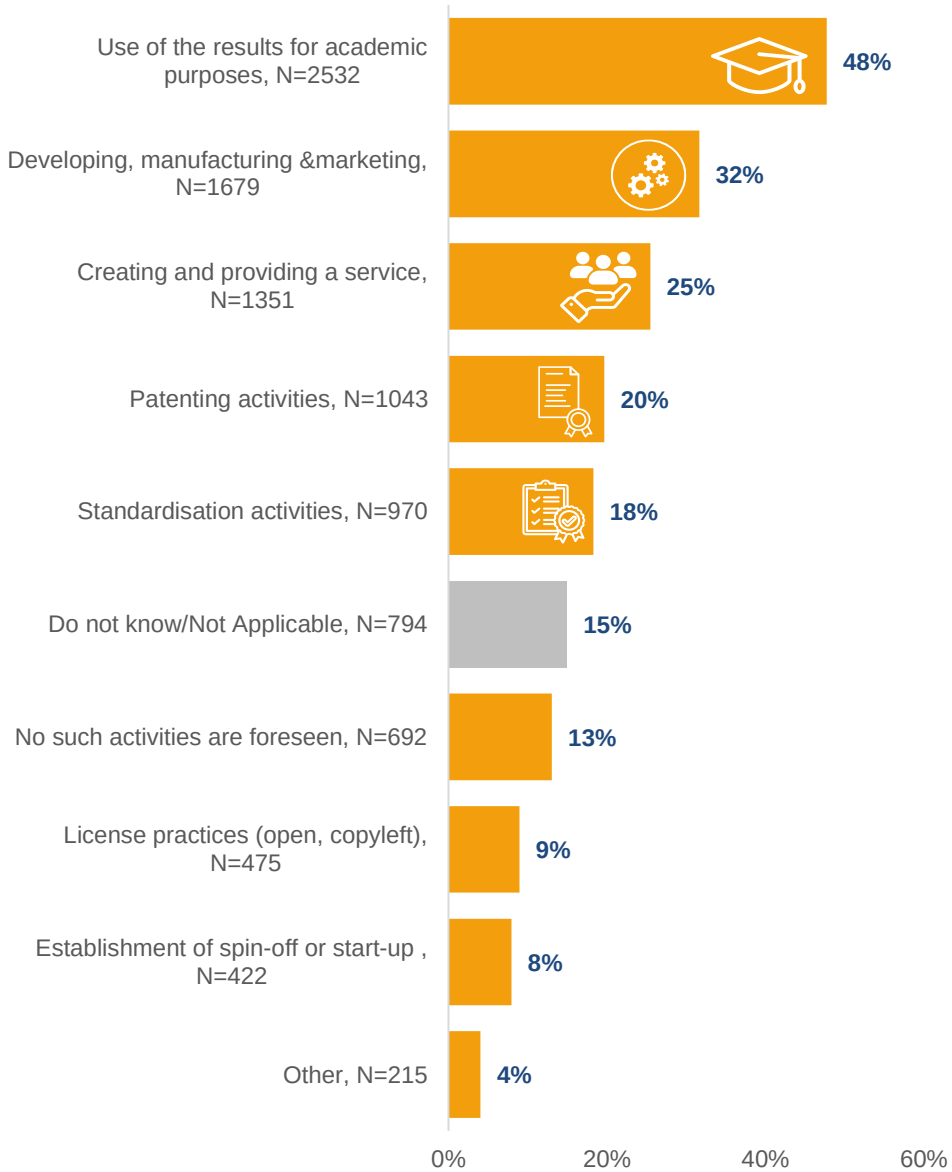


Figure 41 Exploitation activities part of the projects

Programme beneficiaries. Multiple choice question.

*In your opinion, to what extent are the following activities and support actions important to **facilitate the uptake of your research findings and/or innovation**?*

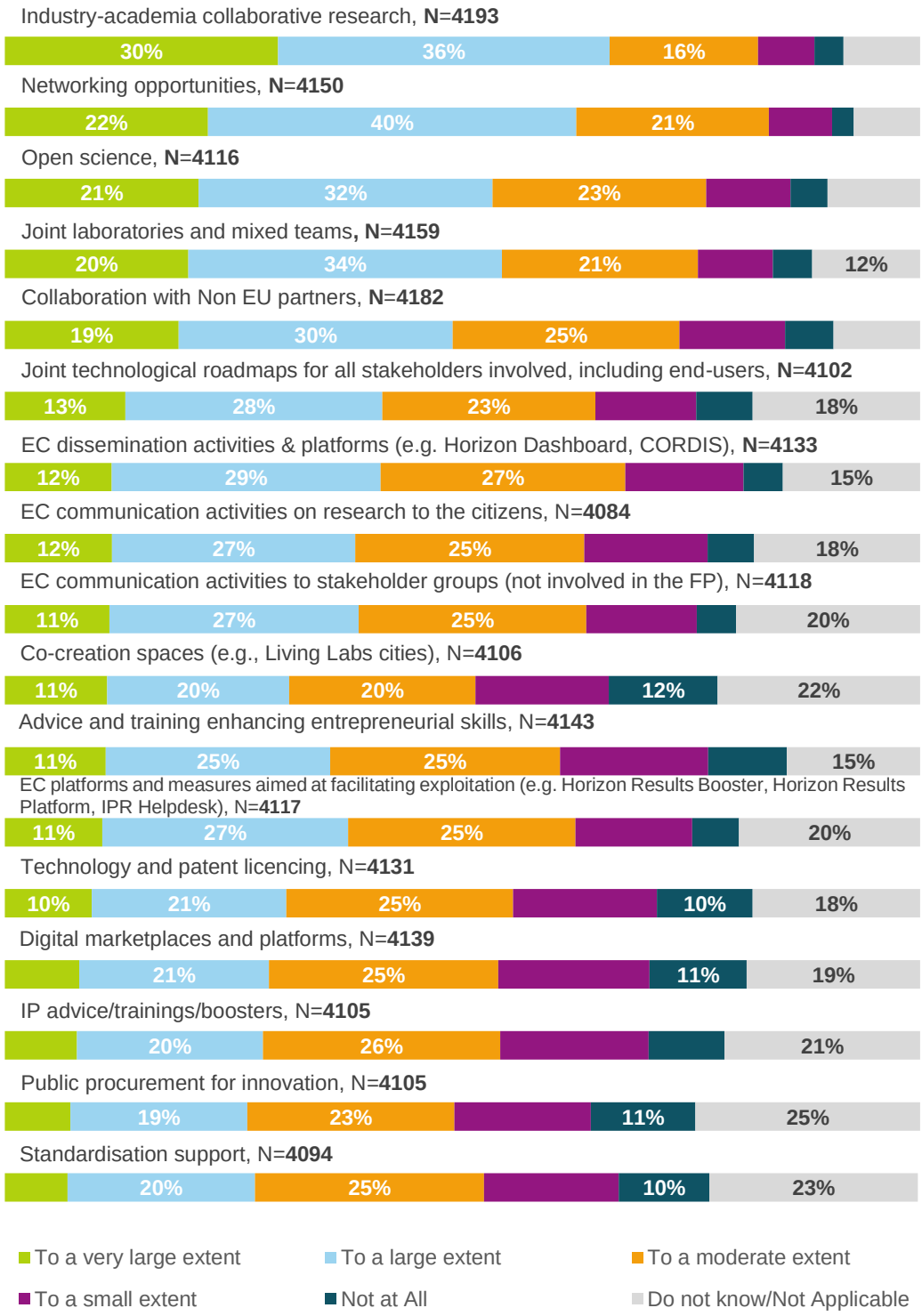


Figure 42 Activities and support actions facilitating the uptake of research findings and/or innovation

Programme beneficiaries, excluding MSCA and ERC participants.

*Which of the following **difficulties or challenges** did you face when publishing project results **in open access**?*



Figure 43 Difficulties or challenges faced when publishing project results in Open Access

Programme beneficiaries, excluding EIC Accelerator participants. Multiple choice question.

*Do you plan to engage **citizens/citizen representatives/end-users in the co-creation** of R&I content of your project?*

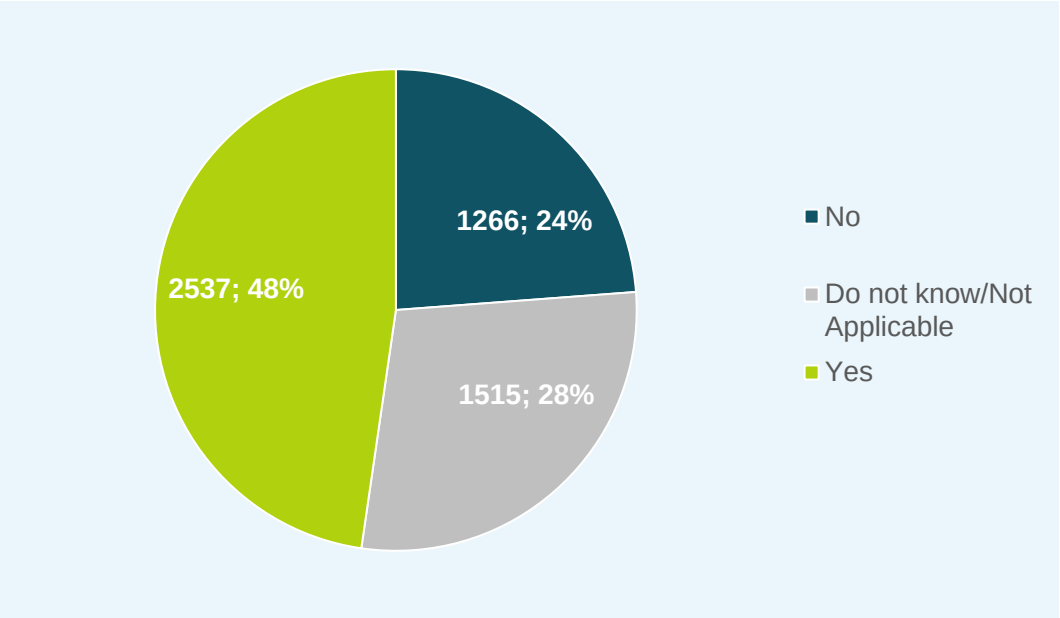


Figure 44 Citizens or end-users' engagement in co-creating R&I content

Programme beneficiaries (N=5318)

*Please specify the **activities used to engage citizens** or end-users in your project*

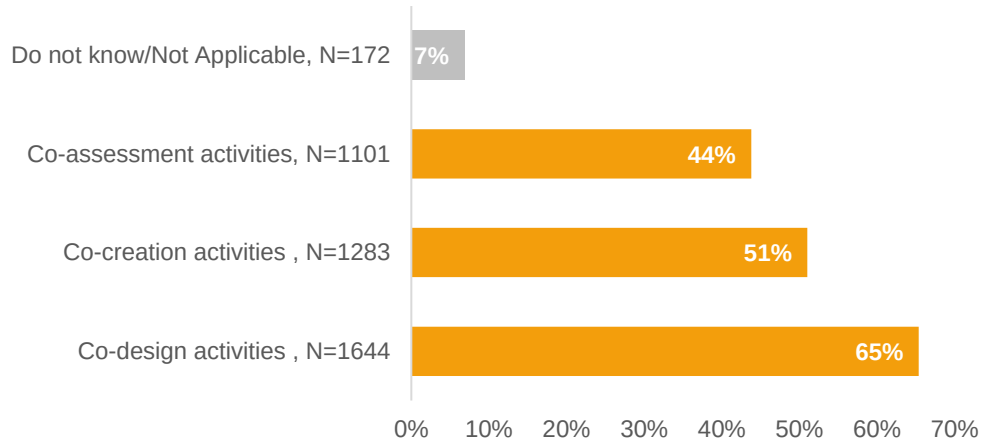


Figure 45 Activities used to engage citizens or end-users

Programme beneficiaries. Multiple choice question.

*What role do **civil society representatives and/or governmental institutions** play in your project's execution?*

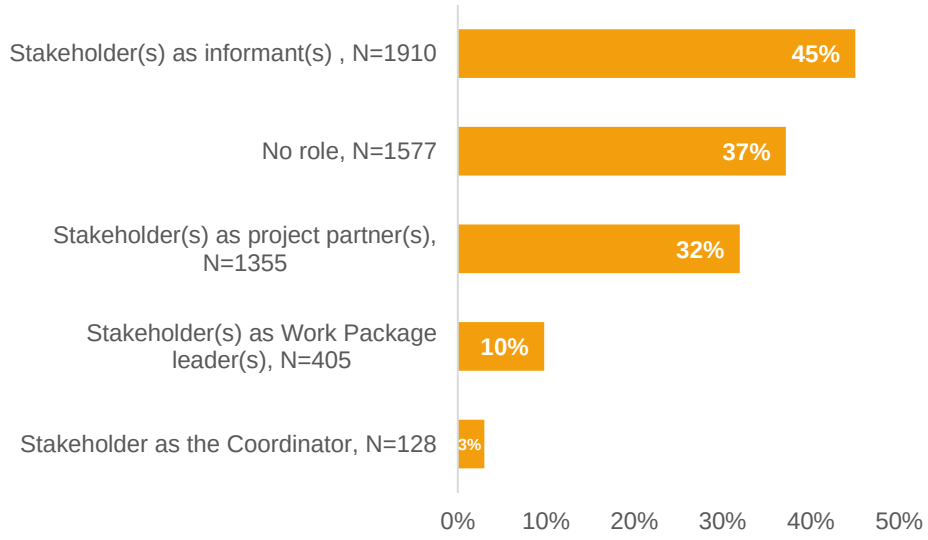


Figure 46 Role of civil society representatives and/or governmental institutions

Programme beneficiaries, excluding MSCA and ERC participants. Multiple choice question. The option "stakeholders as Work Package Leader" was not included in the EIC Accelerator questionnaire.

Civil society representatives include operators of critical infrastructure and local governments of cities/metropolitan areas; consumer organisations, NGOs, firefighting units; medical emergency services, police departments, civil protection units, control command centres, control laboratories, customs authorities.

2.6. EU added value

*Would you agree or disagree that, **compared to the research funding available to you at national and/or regional level**, Horizon Europe:*

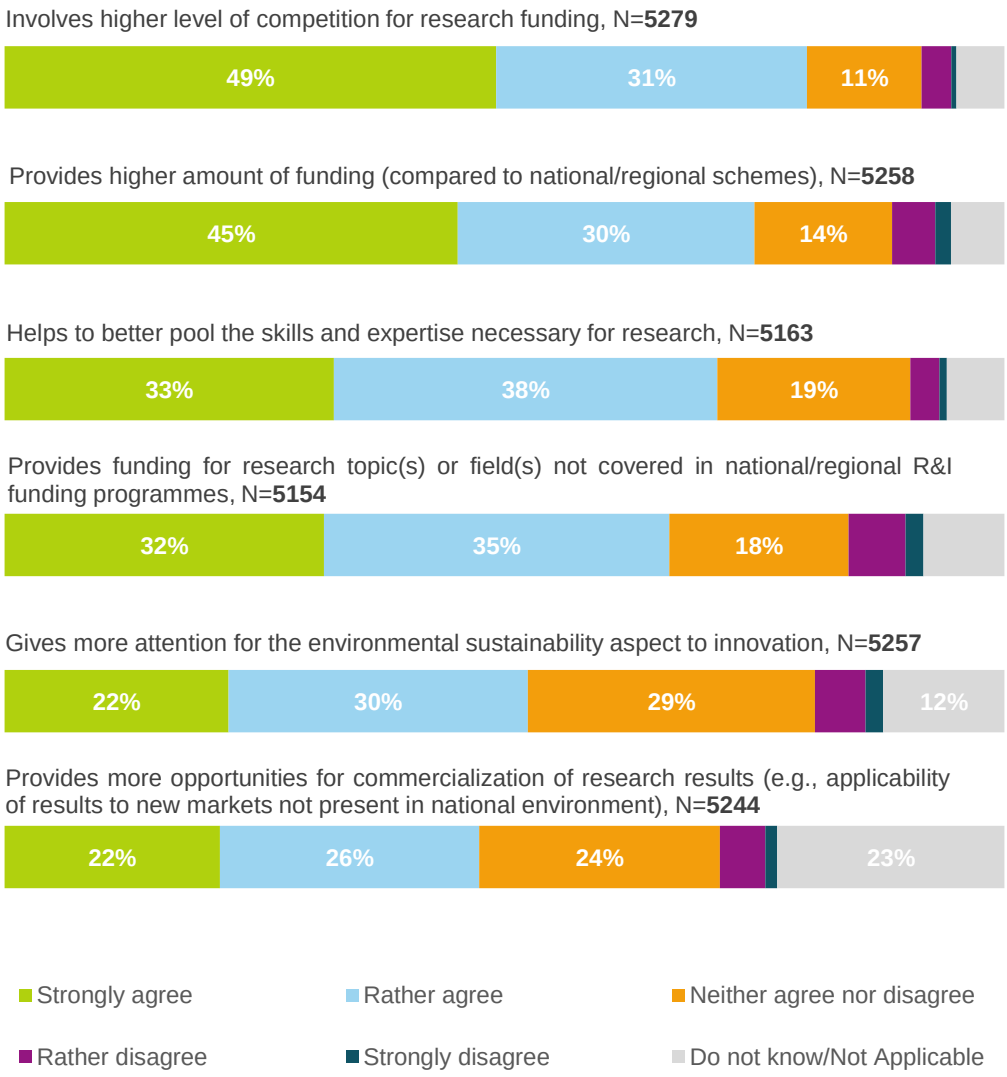


Figure 47 Views on Horizon Europe funding compared to national and regional research funding.

Programme beneficiaries. The options "Helps to better pool the skills and expertise necessary for research", and "Provides funding for research topic(s) or field(s) not covered in national or regional R&I funding programmes" were not included in the EIC Accelerator questionnaire.

2.7. Information about the developments following unsuccessful project application

*Has your organisation **applied for alternative sources of funding** to implement the activities proposed in your Horizon Europe?*

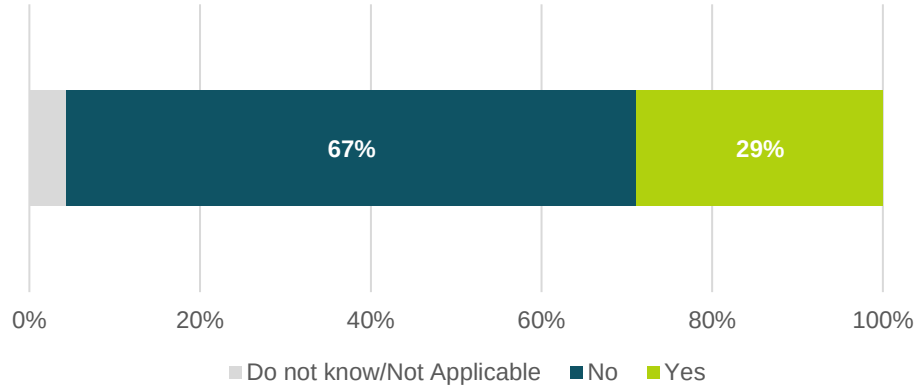


Figure 48 Application for alternative funding sources for Horizon Europe activities

Unsuccessful applicants (N=8963)

Was your application for this alternative funding successful?

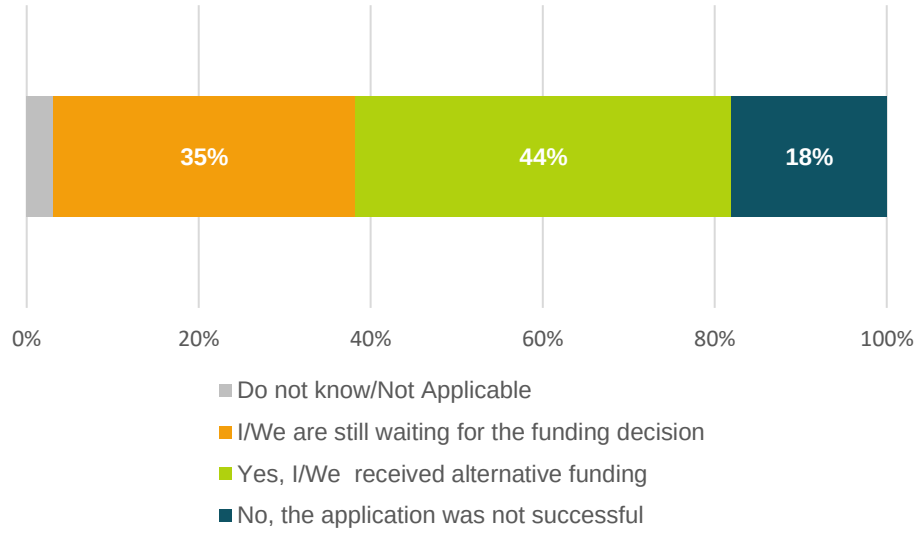


Figure 49 Success of application for alternative funding

Unsuccessful applicants (N=2583)

What were the sources of funding that you received for your project?

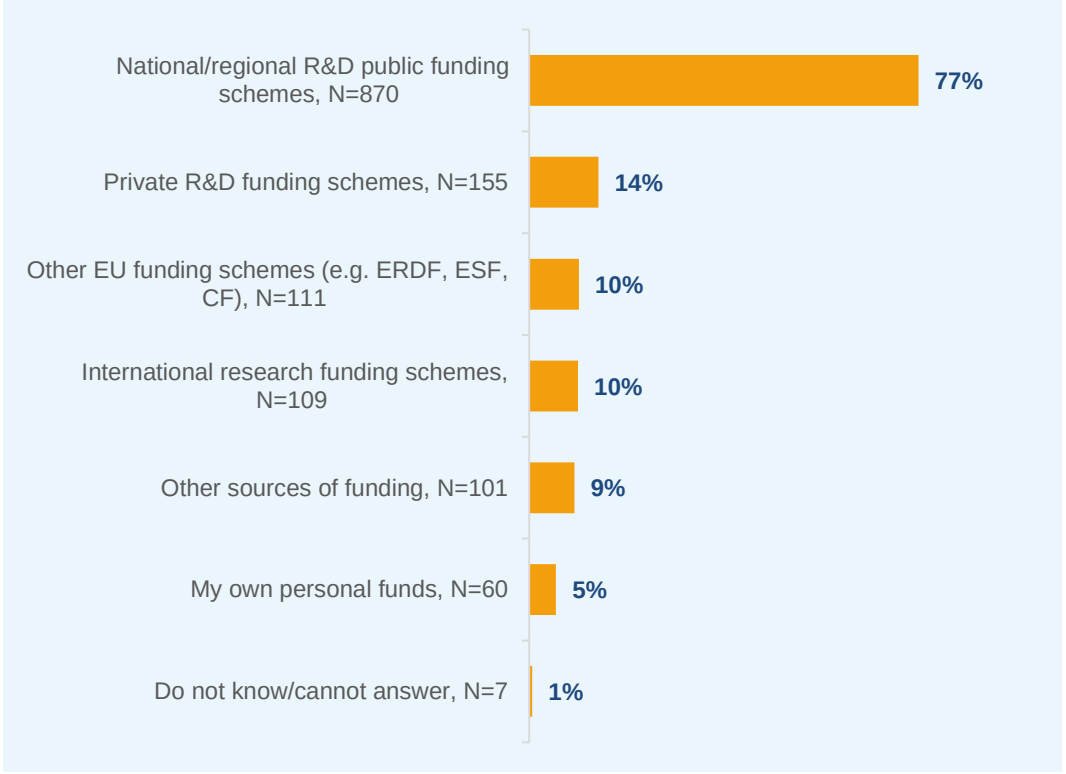


Figure 50 Sources of funding received

Unsuccessful applicants. Multiple choice question

Compared to your original Horizon Europe project application, did the research application for alternative funding involve the following.

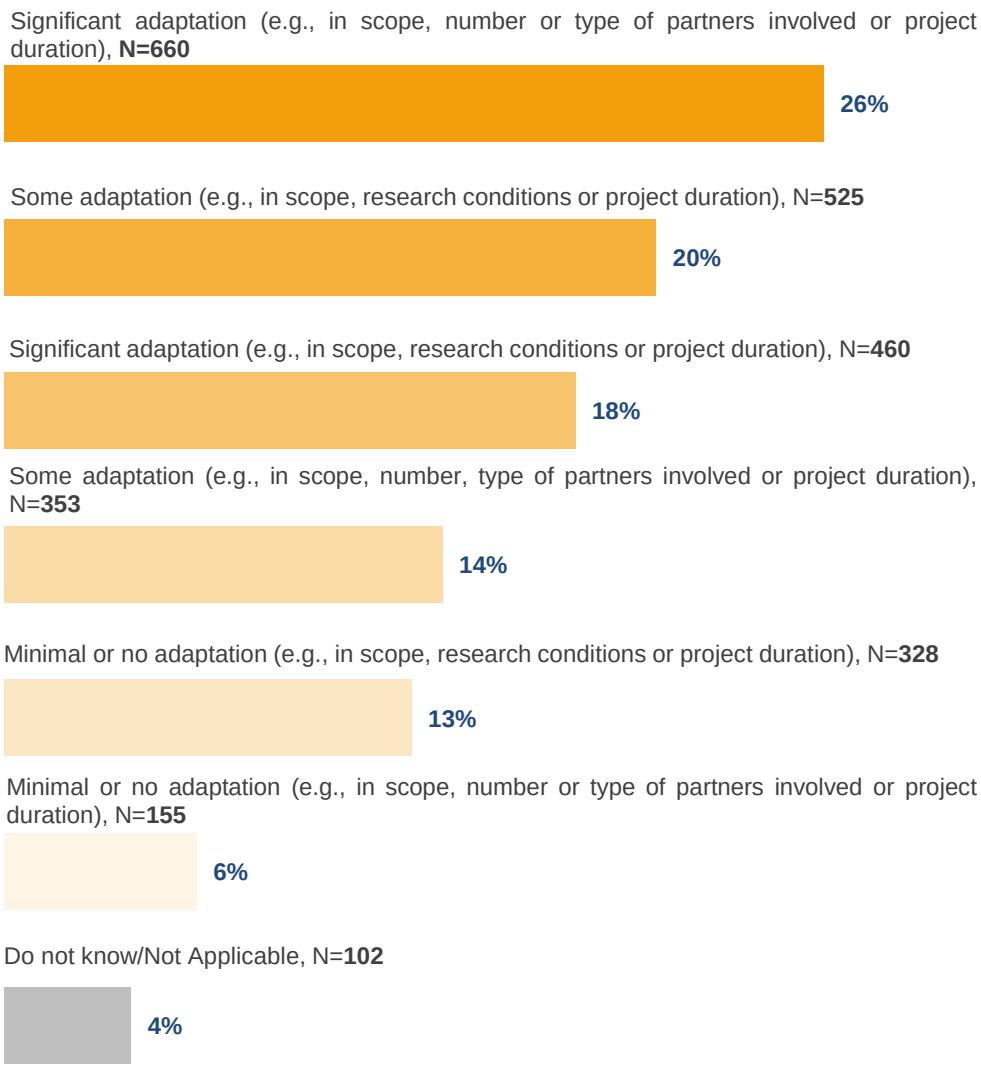


Figure 51 Comparison of research application requirements for alternative funding vs. Horizon Europe

Unsuccessful applicants (N=2583)

Compared to your original programme project application, did this adaptation entail

PROJECT SCOPE

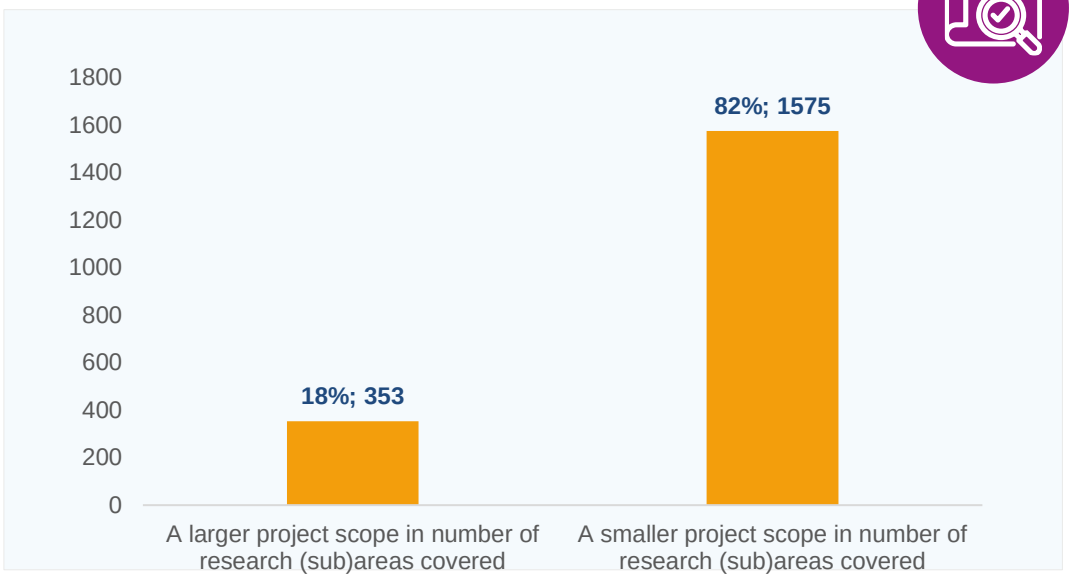


Figure 52 Project scope adaptation compared to original programme application

Unsuccessful applicants (N=1928)

METHODS

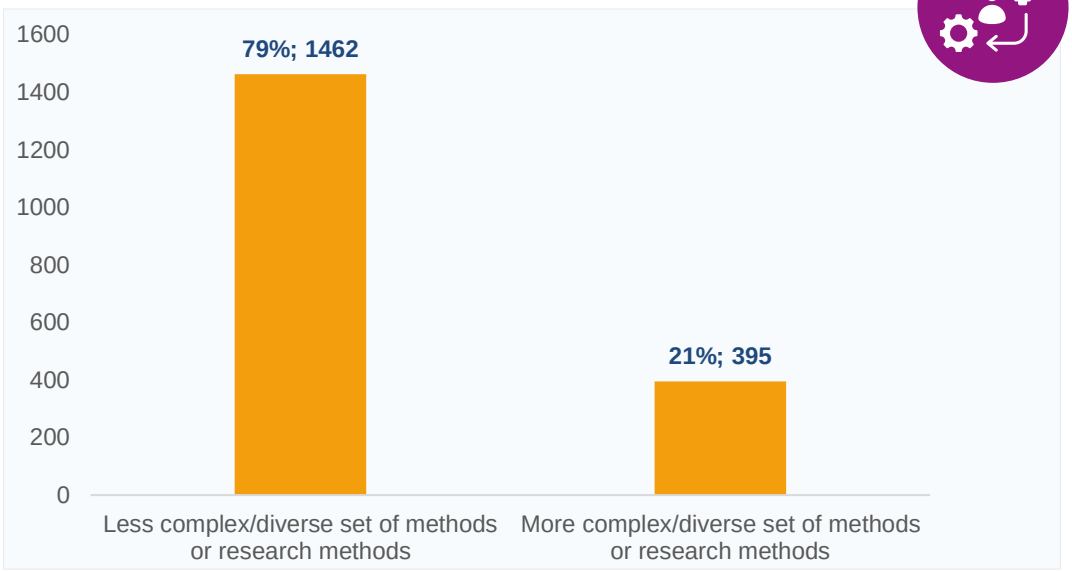


Figure 53 Methods adaptation compared to original programme application

Unsuccessful applicants (N=1857)

RESEARCH OUTPUTS

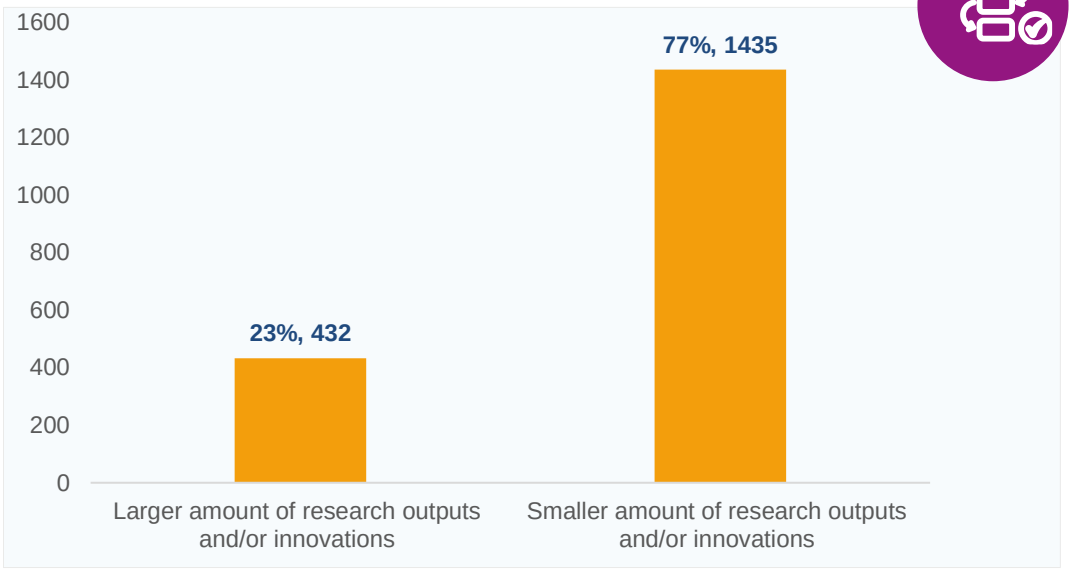


Figure 54 Research outputs' adaptation compared to original programme application

Unsuccessful applicants (N=1867)

DURATION

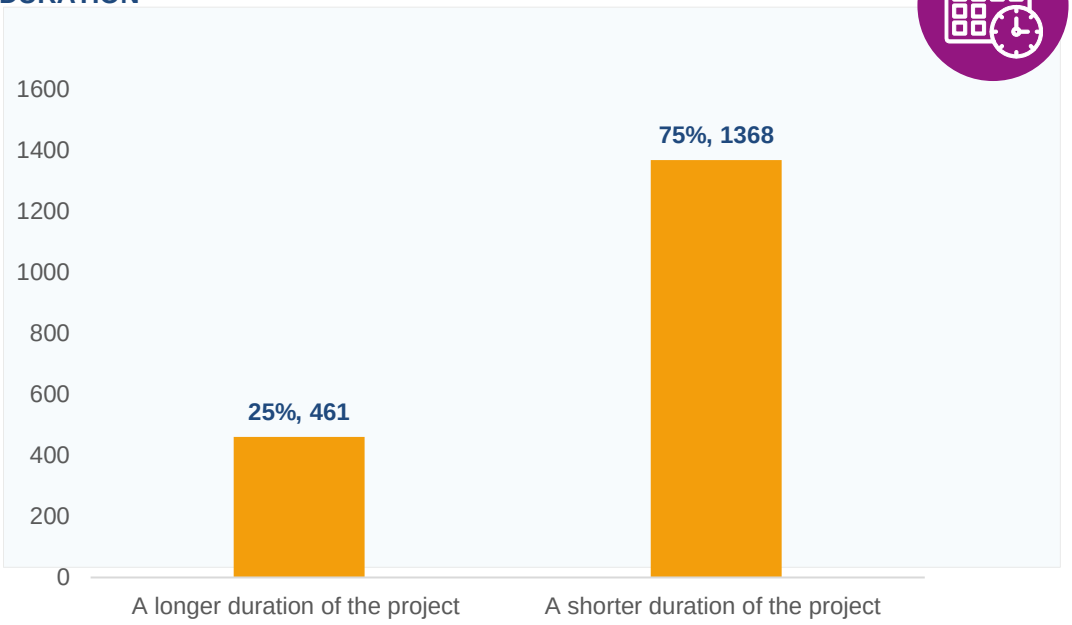


Figure 55 Duration adaptation compared to original programme application

Unsuccessful applicants (N=1829)

PARTNER NUMBERS

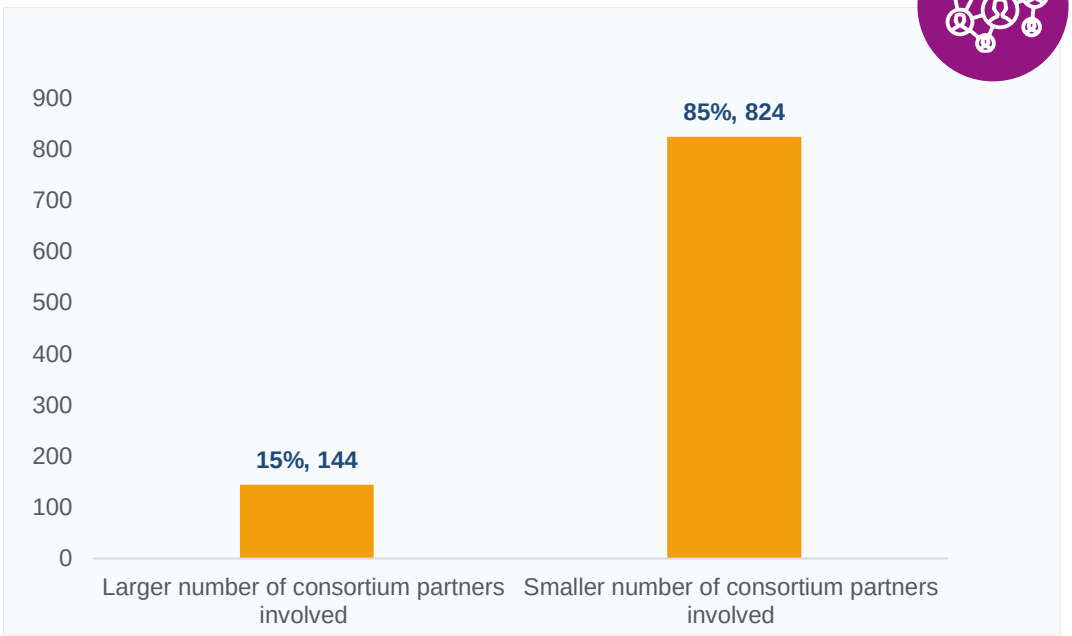


Figure 56 Partner numbers adaptation compared to original programme application

Unsuccessful applicants excluding the MSCA and ERC where only individuals apply (N=968)

PARTNER PROFILE

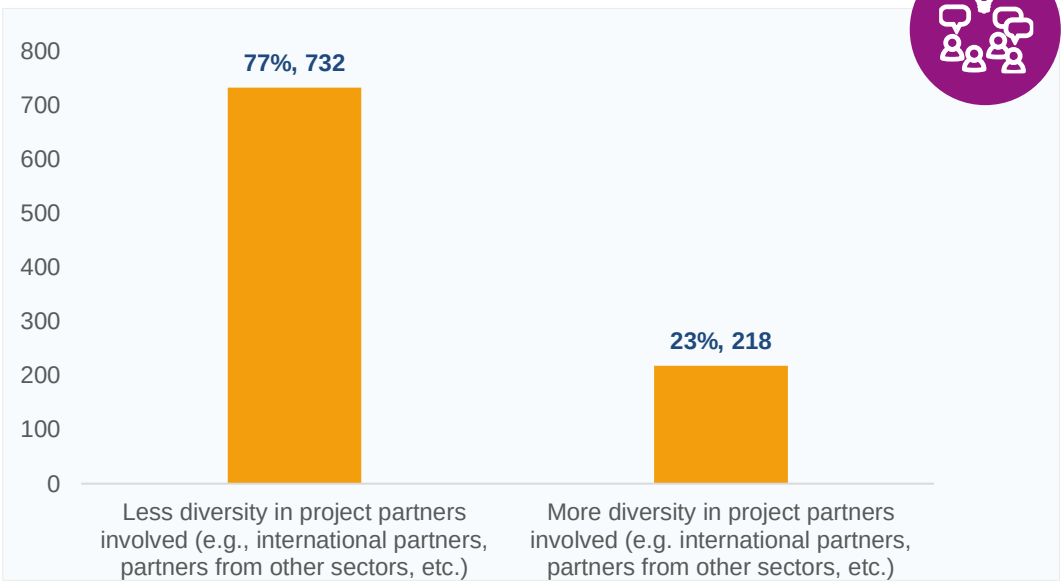


Figure 57 Partner profile adaptation compared to original programme application

Unsuccessful applicants excluding MSCA and ERC (N=950)

RESEARCH CONDITIONS

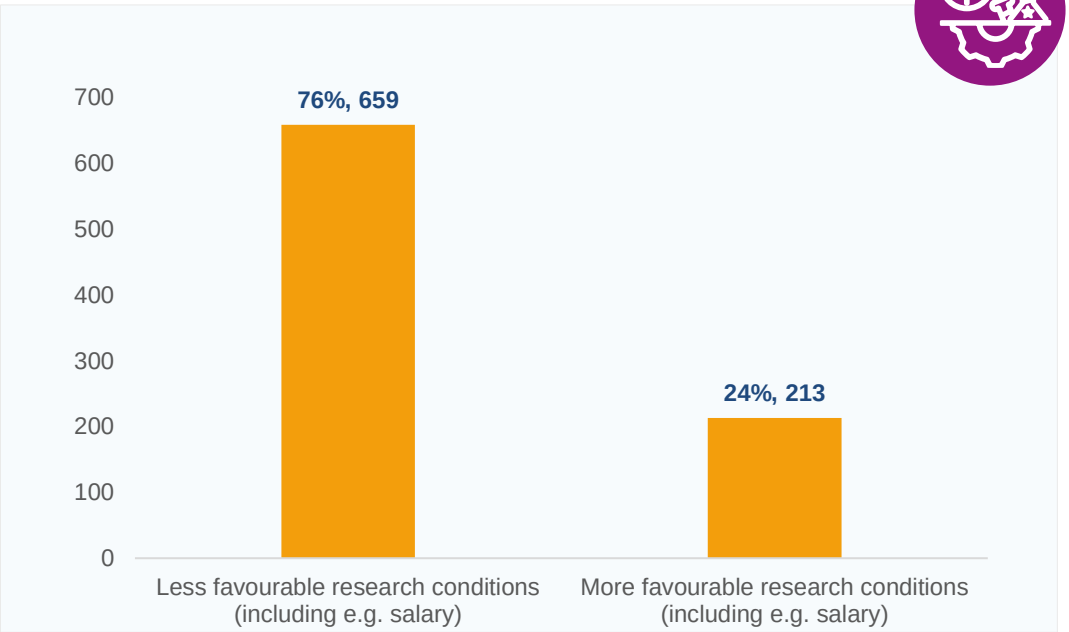


Figure 58 Research conditions adaptation compared to original programme application

ERC and MSCA Unsuccessful applicants (N=872)

*Did the **Seal of Excellence** received for your unsuccessful project proposal make it easier for you to secure the funding from national/regional funding sources?*

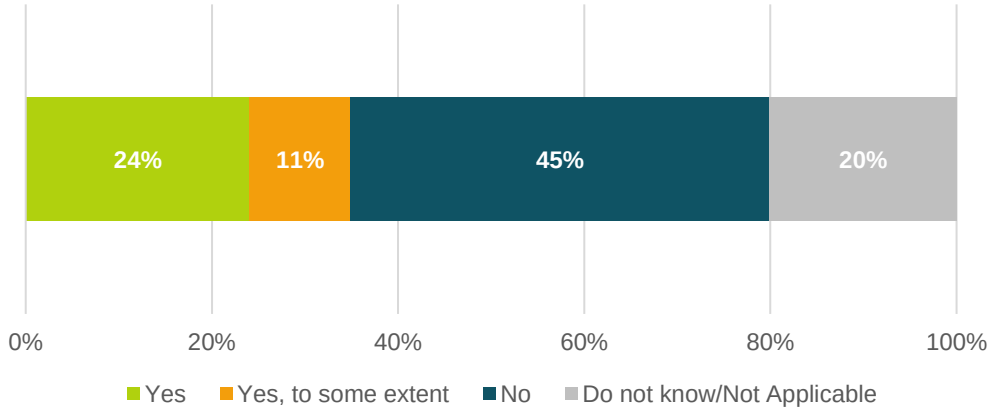


Figure 59 Impact of Seal of Excellence on securing national/regional funding

Unsuccessful applicants (N=129).

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This report presents the results of the analysis of a survey of beneficiaries and unsuccessful applicants in Horizon Europe. The survey was conducted between May and July 2023 to support the interim evaluation of the programme. Independent contractors developed and administered nine online questionnaires to gather evidence on the needs and motives for engaging with Horizon Europe, and obstacles encountered during the application and project implementation. Five studies conducted by external evaluators, each covering a broad thematic area of the Horizon Europe programme, reported the survey results focusing on specific programme parts. The purpose of the report at hand is to present the programme-level results and support the Commission's evaluation of Horizon Europe.

Studies and reports

Publications Office
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